



THE HUNATE SERIES

History of The Joon Project

The life and the years that grew into Hunate

Khem Raj Pradhan

HUMANITY · NATURE · TECHNOLOGY · IN BALANCE

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KHEM RAJ PRADHAN

*This is not an NGO, a company, a political party, or a religion.
It is a life, and a way of living, shared in the open.*

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Part of the Hunate Series

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A NOTE TO THE READER

On Truth and Names

This is a true story, told from memory, and memory is its own kind of truth. I have told it as honestly as I can.

I have kept my own life open on these pages, with nothing hidden. But this is not only my story; it touches many other people, some of whom did not choose to be written about. To protect their privacy, I have changed or set aside the names and identifying details of others where it seemed right. What remains is only the shape of a life that was truly lived.

This is for every human of this world, young, adult, old, and those yet to be born. I want every one of us to understand the self, to understand nature and its elements, and to understand our tools and technologies, and to keep peace and harmony among them all. This is our home. It is all our responsibility to understand it, protect it, and help preserve it.

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FOREWORD

Where It Begins

I did not write this book because my life is special. I wrote it because it is true, and because I have come to believe that we heal only what we are honest about.

What you are holding is the first of six books. It is my own story, told plainly, from before my birth in a Bhojpur village to the day a small project on locked-down farmland became the beginning of Hunate. I have hidden nothing of myself. You will find beauty here, and you will find hard things, loss and cruelty and hunger and the long, slow work of becoming. I have left the hard things in, not to shock you, but because they are where I learned the most, and because someone, somewhere, is carrying the same things in silence, and I want them to know they are not alone.

If you are looking for a man who had it all figured out, this is the wrong book. I was a lost, angry, addicted boy who kept walking, from a dark room toward a distant light, and who slowly began to ask why the world is built the way it is, and could not stop asking. Everything else in Hunate, the philosophy, the design, the movement, grew out of this. This story is the root.

Where I speak of people who once hurt me, I have tried to speak with forgiveness, because I have learned that everyone is doing what their own wounds taught them, and that understanding is the only door out. If you take one thing from these pages, let it be this: that we are all connected, that we become what surrounds us, and that it is never too late to begin again.

Read it slowly. And if something in you recognises what I am saying, then you already belong here.

Khem Raj Pradhan

PART ONE

Roots

*A boy born among the cattle, a family made
and broken, and the long road out of the hills.*

CHAPTER ONE

Before I Remember

Before Birth

This is a story I heard from my parents and my relatives. My parents were both from Bhojpur, my dad from a place called Bastim, my mom from a place called Amtek. The two villages were about a five-hour walk apart. There were no roads, no transport, and no electricity in that region back then. My dad came from a Pradhan, Newar family; my mom came from a Parajuli, Brahmin family. Mom was the eldest daughter, and every sibling in her family was sent to school, because they were literate people. My dad's family was not the same, he was the only one who got the privilege to study. Grandma and Dad used to say that he stole garlic and sold it to pay for his studies, and that Grandma caught him many times and punished him for it. Later he even left home and went to a city called Biratnagar to study on his own. He worked during the day and attended night school.

After that, Dad came back to Bhojpur and started another journey. He was in the communist party at the time, going from village to village spreading the communist message and recruiting people. That is how he met Mom, he came to her

village with her younger uncle. It was about two hours from Mom's place and around seven hours from Dad's. Later they met again in Bhojpur Bazar, in college, and joined hands in politics. They became comrades, and rivals. Dad was into music; Mom was outgoing and loved to dance. They fell in love.

After some time they decided to marry. But inter-caste marriage was not accepted back then, so they chose to run away and marry with the support of their communist friends.

(Nepal was a Hindu country back then, still following ancient social systems, and so we had a caste system in practice. Even now we carry those hierarchies into our modern world. People criticize our ancient cultures these days without understanding their era, their language, their value, their purpose. To me it was simply a way to divide roles and responsibilities in a community, just as we now use titles like doctor, pilot, farmer, cleaner, carpenter. Everyone has a role and a responsibility in society. Someone did try to misuse the caste system in the name of religion, and the rulers made a bad implementation of it. Or maybe Western culture began calling Eastern cultures bad and inhuman while it renamed the same things and practiced them under a more "civilized," systematic label. It's complicated.)

They ran. They went to a place called Damak to take shelter with my dad's older brother, who was already living there. Damak was two days from Bhojpur, a bigger city, with roads, transport, electricity, and modern culture. Soon both my dad's and my mom's parents accepted them and called them back to the village.

Back home, my parents kept up their communist work and went into social service. They built schools, brought water tanks and taps to the villages, and taught the old people. Be-

fore that there was no tap water in the village, not even a school; they gathered the resources, and they helped and guided the village to build them. They were always working, going from village to village. This whole journey of my parents, questioning and searching for new ways to live, was engraved in their whole being: mind, body, and soul. And that is where I was born, out of their union.

Birth

I was born in Bastim, Bhojpur, Nepal, on the thirteenth of November. My parents used to say I was born in the animal shelter, among the cows and buffaloes. Our house had four separate structures: one main building for the family, one of similar size for the animals, one for grinding and storage, and one for miscellaneous use.

I was born in the animal shelter. It was normal back then. Most children were born wherever the mother happened to be working at the time, in the field, on the road, in the jungle. Our mothers did not use pregnancy as an excuse to stop using their bodies, and I think that is one reason those born that way grew into stronger humans. Today it is criticized as an unhealthy ritual of illiterate villagers, but that is not how it looks to me now.

(Look, houses were made of mud, and mud soaks up blood very easily. A floor soaked in blood attracts flies, insects, and bacteria, infecting everything, so there had to be a way to manage it. I understand now why menstruating women were kept apart; it was for the same reason and purpose. There is a wrong narrative about this in the modern

world. Everything had a reason in its own era. There were no soaps and hygienic chemicals like we have now, so it had to be done in other ways, and I believe they had their own natural methods to prevent infection and the spread of disease. This makes me think about the modern approach, trying to kill every last bacterium in the body in the name of health, constantly using sanitizers, soaps, and factory-made chemicals. I strongly believe we should learn to understand nature and use it as much as we can. Ayurveda from the East, and many other cultures, hold natural knowledge that the modern economy and the health industry have hidden or neglected. And if you ask me why, it is because it does not make them money.)

When I was born, they say my grandma was the happiest person alive. She came and sat beside my mother and me, day and night, and took care of us. She even threw a celebration for it in the village. You see, in our home it was Grandma who was the administrator, not Grandpa. She was the leader, the ruler, a highly respected and feared woman in the whole village. Strict, sharp, disciplined, clean, and clear, and yet very helpful and generous too. I remember people coming to her to ask for food, seeds, money, advice, blessings. She was very charismatic. She knew what was right, above family and above any emotional bond.

(In modern times, a person with strong will, discipline, and a clear sense of morality and justice is sometimes misread as cold, inhuman, even evil or antisocial. But it reminds me of a conversation from one of our ancient books, between Lord Krishna and a disciple. The disciple asks, "Dear God, why should I fight my own family? I don't think I can, they are my family." And the Lord replies, "Fight to know the truth; fight for truth and righteousness." My grandma was such a

woman. I admire this trait in leaders. I call it emotional intelligence too, the ability to make the right decision regardless of family or favoritism.)

This is proof that keeping my mother and me in the animal shelter was not discrimination or bad practice. It was a necessary thing. After my birth, my parents kept travelling and teaching in different villages, and I spent my time with my grandparents and the joint family. I drank milk from the cows and buffaloes, and from my grandmother's empty breast. Life went on, and then one day everything crashed.

This too is only a story I have heard, though there are faint burn marks on my right hand to prove it. They say we used to keep cans and gallons of milk, ghee, and curd in our home. One day they had heated butter and were making ghee. They left the hot ghee to cool, and I, curious as always, went and jumped into that big pot. It burned me, most of it down the right side of my body. I must have cried a lot. But as my parents say, I never cried easily from physical pain; in that way I was an easy child. I didn't cry much, I didn't wet or dirty the bed without warning, but I was unstoppable.

The Second Wife

My younger brother was about to be born when a rumour began to grow in the village. An unmarried girl from the Tamang community had become pregnant, and the rumour spread like thunder, and it pointed back to my father. They said he had an affair with her, and that she was carrying

his child. The villagers forced her into our family, and she came to live with us. Nothing was ever the same again, especially for my mother and my grandmother.

All that social work, all those good deeds, all that teaching, all those years of fighting to be accepted as an inter-caste couple, all of it was smashed in a single moment. I wonder how that must have felt. A betrayal. A broken promise. Broken trust. It was already a struggle to live and to prove their foreign ideas, and now this.

My brother was born soon after. Mom was struggling to find her place and her purpose there. She stopped teaching and going out; Dad stopped going out. Everything shut down. So Mom decided to leave that home and start again somewhere else. I was two; my brother was newly born. And my grandmother supported the idea, Grandma always supported her.

Grandma told Mom to go to my oldest uncle's place in Damak for a while, to find land, buy a shop, and build a place of her own, and she gave her enough money to do it. But she insisted on keeping me behind. Grandma said it would be too hard with two children at the start, and she promised to bring me to Damak when it was time for me to start school and my brother was a little older.

So one night, before the sun came up, my mother left in silence, carrying my baby brother on her back, climbing the hills alone with her belongings, watching home fade behind her. Crying tears of broken trust, broken love, a broken heart, leaving behind everything it had taken years to build in that

village. I am sure she kissed me goodbye before she left me sleeping. I am sure she cried out all her heart and lungs, alone with my brother in the dark.

Mom's Life in Damak

I don't know exactly what happened there. From what I have heard, the money she carried was used up by my oldest uncle, and Mom could not buy her land or her shop. So she took shelter with his family and helped in their small restaurant, a khaja ghar. It was hard to adjust; theirs was already a large family. So she bought her own little shop, a ghumti, and started her own venture.

She decided to move again, to a place called Kherkhera, within Damak. She said the villagers there were more accepting, they gave her shelter, support, and love. Grandma again sent money and helped her get a piece of land. A cousin, Bishnu, the eldest son of one of my uncles from Bhojpur, older than me, came to stay with her. So it was Mom, my little brother, and Bishnu there. Mom farmed, ran her shop, and taught the villagers how to read and write. She found her place. She built her own independent space. She became a villager. And when she felt she was ready, she called for me.

Meanwhile, I was being me, free of my parents. Dad had left home too. Out of shame and guilt, maybe, he went somewhere no one knew. I was living with the joint family and my stepmother, who then left as well, after giving birth to my stepbrother. Her own father had forced her to marry another man

from the Tamang community, so she left to marry him, leaving her child with our family; a few months later they took the child too.

And so I lived wild, without parents, pampered and loved by everyone, and at the same time lacking a parent's proper attention and guidance. Crawling here and there, jumping from lap to lap, sipping rice beer from my grandfather's and my uncle's cups.

First Memory, From a Dark Room to the Light

This is one of the first memories I count in my life. I usually slept with my grandmother on the first floor, where my father's bed also stood in one corner, though he was rarely there. Sometimes I slept with my middle uncle, sometimes with my father, who mostly slept outside the house.

I remember waking in a dark room, some light coming through the holes in the wooden window, and a loud noise of people in the distance. It was Grandma's room. I woke alone in the dark because of that noise, and I could feel there was no one else in the room. I cried, calling for my grandmother, but no one came. So I climbed down from the bed by myself, crawling, I don't know whether I fell or landed safely. I was crying and calling for help, because I was scared, and it was dark, and I could not get down alone. I didn't know what to make of all that light and noise reaching me. It was something new.

I crawled from the door toward the stairs, narrow wooden stairs, the typical kind tucked into the corner of a hill house. Once I reached the ground floor I saw light coming from the

main door to my left, and I crawled toward it. When I got there I saw, blurred through my tears, many people celebrating together, Dashain, or Tihar, dancing and singing late into the night with the whole community: food, music, alcohol, fireworks, all in our home. The whole journey from the bed to the front door must have taken me more than thirty minutes. I must have woken in the middle of the celebration, and by the time I reached it, it was ending.

I stopped crying, in wonder. I held the beam of the wooden doorway and slowly stood up, my vision still clearing from the tears and the light. The music stopped; the eating and talking began. Someone noticed me, picked me up, and set me on their hip, the way we carry children in Nepal.

I still remember that night. It is still with me. I don't know what meaning it holds, but I cherish it; it is dear to me. Maybe the journey itself, coming from darkness into light, is something I was meant to remember, to learn from, to be ready for in life. Patience, persistence, fearlessness, self-reliance, independence: these are the things I take from it. Maybe this is what keeps me going.

CHAPTER TWO

The Radio and the Aeroplane

I remember this time very well, though whether it was truly my first journey to Damak, I am no longer sure. My father was in Bhojpur Bazar. I was in a village in Bhojpur, and my grandmother and my oldest aunt had to take me down to the bazaar, to the airport, to fly to Biratnagar and then on to Damak, to my mom.

I was terrified. I didn't want to leave home, and I didn't understand what was happening. But I was taken anyway, crying and crying while they tried to calm me. I remember grabbing at anything I could to stay, bamboo along the path, plants, rocks, while they kept pulling me along. I was screaming, calling out, "Father, father, save me." They kept promising we would meet my father at the bazaar, but for some reason I didn't believe them, and I kept fighting and shouting.

To settle me, they let me carry a radio, which I played as I walked. That radio was a luxury there in those days, and strongly built too, I remember playing it for years afterward, whenever we visited the Bhojpur family. They say I even slept with it when I slept beside my middle uncle. It was his radio.

After a six- or seven-hour walk, we reached Bhojpur Bazar and the airport. I was happy to see my dad there; I thought we were all going together. And there I saw an aeroplane for the first time. I started crying again, frightened, I couldn't make sense of what it was: how it flew, its shape, its size, its colour. Even the people stepping out of it frightened me. I began fighting everyone, crying my lungs out, trying to run away from it.

It was a marvel of what a human being could build. It was my first impression of technology. The radio was already my whole world, and now here was an aeroplane, one I could not carry. I didn't understand who could have made such a thing. I might have thought they were gods coming down from the sky. I don't know how my family explained these things to me, or whether they ever bothered to.

At the gate I saw strange, beautiful women. What could I have known back then? Those air hostesses were lovely in their traditional dress, the sari, welcoming everyone with folded hands, "Namaste." They were the most beautiful, clean, fair figures I had ever seen, with their make-up and all. In the village I had only ever seen women worn down by work and the dust of the fields. Maybe I thought these women were not even human, and that frightened me too. I still remember my crying now.

Somehow my dad got me inside and made me sit. The hostesses tried to pamper me with sweets, but I smashed them, threw the straw, and kept crying and struggling to get away. When it was time to fly, my dad slipped off the aeroplane and left me, and I wonder still how I kept crying and fighting through the whole flight. I don't remember reaching Birat-

nagar, or Damak, or my mother. I must have looked out of the window and cried even more. Maybe I felt we were flying to heaven, to god's own place. Maybe I could make no sense of the land below, all those hills, clouds, and rivers seen from above. If I could, I would love to live those experiences again, as a child.

That is how this world is: technology, science, the language of nature, all of it can look like magic to someone who does not yet understand it.

PART TWO

A Boyhood in Damak

*A wild boy meets the wider world, bicycles
and festivals, schools and punishments, the
long walk home to the hills, and the things a
child is shown too early.*

CHAPTER THREE

A New World

Coming to a new place, Damak felt strange to me. I was fascinated by how developed it was compared to Bhojpur. Here I saw bicycles, rickshaws, motorbikes, buses. I was curious and frightened at once. I used to wait for a rickshaw or a motorbike to come down our road from a distance, and when it passed I would run behind it, as if chasing it, maybe I liked the way it threw up dust with its dirty tyres, the wind it dragged behind, the fascinating patterns the dust made in the air.

Somehow, Dad came and joined the family too. Mom said he had asked for forgiveness; he faced the villagers' judgement, was accepted, and started living with us again. Dad ran a shop and Mom did the housework and this and that. We had rented a two-storey wooden house. Our neighbours were the Rai family, three children, the oldest son, a middle sister, and a youngest son, and we were three: me, my little brother, and my cousin Bishnu. They were our friends in need and in deed: humble, fun, helpful, hardworking, and brave.

I remember playing with Dad and my brother, him lifting the two of us on his legs in bed. I remember Dad and me holding my little brother up, teaching him to walk, saying “Ta, ta,” which is like “left, right” in English. These are some of the early, happy moments of my dad simply being a dad. I wonder how it must have felt to learn that I had a little brother and to be meeting him, living with him, after years apart. My parents must have introduced us and told me to always protect him, and told him to always look up to me. I think that is how most families work, naturally and socially both.

Grandma visited us too. I remember she cooked her own food; I don’t think my grandma ever ate food cooked by another person. The villagers gave me the name “Sagar,” which means ocean, because I had deep eyes and would stare at things with unusual focus and concentration. And why wouldn’t I? I was four, and the whole world had flipped for me, aeroplanes, electricity, concrete houses, flat land, vehicles, crowds of people every day. I was a free, wild spirit. I didn’t listen to my parents much. If someone said, “Don’t do this,” I would do exactly that and then report back proudly: “I did it.”

The Leech

I remember a rice planting, the whole village out in the fields. It was a wonderful time, water everywhere, fishing, swimming, playing in the mud with the village kids. In the middle of the paddy, a leech fastened onto Mom’s hand. I don’t know if it was a big one, but she was bleeding, and I was scared to death at the sight of it. I began crying loudly, which irritated her. To her it was ordinary; to me it was new. She

slapped me quiet and told me to run home and bring the Handyplus, so I ran like never before. I don't remember what happened after that.

I think that taught me to be rational, to act on a problem rather than sit and cry over it. That leech was no great matter to my mother; she already knew how to deal with it, pull it off, dab on some medicine, keep planting. But to me it was like watching a person die. She taught me to do the necessary thing and carry on. In life there are thousands of problems, and sometimes one person's problem is another's solution. That one event taught me to see a single thing from many sides. There is no true start or end in life; it is always change, and the only question is where to apply your force.

I remember the food we ate at planting and harvest, out on the fields with the villagers, rice cooked with oil and cumin, potato pickle, and dry spinach pickle we call gundruk. I loved the food and the feeling of the working community: children leaping in the hay, shouting and running, the grown-ups pretending to scold us, teasing us, talking about us among themselves. It is a pleasant thing to remember, a dreamy community of working heroes, happy and supportive and connected. And I remember sleeping in our little shop, the ghumti, where at night I could sneak a few sweets and biscuits. My dad was not fond of factory food and kept it away from us, even though we sold it. That is how this system works: even when you don't want to be part of a failing system, you are forced to live inside it and support it, one way or another.

The Festival of Colours

One day I was with my cousin Bishnu, just idling near our shop, when a group of frightening people appeared, covered in colours and dark with dye. They surrounded my brother and started attacking him. It happened out of nowhere, as if they had been hiding. I began to cry and to fight them, pushing and pulling with what little strength my fear had left me. I was very small, maybe five.

They were turning my brother dark like themselves. I grew more frightened, looking around in tears, until I saw firewood near me. I grabbed it and charged them with all the fear and bravery and emergency strength I had. Finally they noticed me and stopped, scattering, confused, and then they began to laugh. Everyone was covered in the dark colour, even my brother, even, I realised, me. It was a festival. They explained what it was, how it was celebrated, and then I cooled down and felt relief. When we don't understand a thing, it takes time, explanation, curiosity, and patience to understand it. That patience can solve almost anything.

My Mother, the Teacher

I remember my mother carrying my brother on her back in her shawl, holding my hand with one hand and her books and an oil lamp, a laltin, in the other, walking the dark village streets. It was a daily thing: she taught the old aunts and villagers how to read and write Nepali. We would come home tired, late in the night, after her classes.

I remember the beggars, or saints, or wandering people who came through the villages asking for food and money, sometimes in black, sometimes red, yellow, or white. There was a rule not to eat anything they gave, and our parents warned us not to go near them alone, especially the ones in black with big beards and long hair. On certain nights, around midnight or before dawn, saints would come blowing the conch, the shankha, and it was terrifying in the dark. I remember men on bicycles who traded fried bhujia and chatpata for our scrap iron, plastic, and bottles. And I remember the ice-cream man on his bicycle, and others who brought chewing gum on long bamboo sticks, or that fluffy pink cloud of candy. I don't remember buying much from them; our parents scared us, saying such men would carry us away, perhaps because they didn't want us wasting money on unhealthy things, or had none to spare. I don't remember minding. We were happy just as we were.

CHAPTER FOUR

The First School

I don't remember my first day at Mechi Higher Secondary Boarding School. I think I was curious and eager to go, because my mother taught in the village and I was fascinated by her. An older boy from the village guided us there.

First Blood

I remember standing under the kimbu, the mulberry tree, at tiffin time. Someone threw a brick up to knock down some fruit, and the sharp piece struck my head. I began to bleed heavily. They took me to the office, called my mother, gave me first aid, and sent me home. It was the first big wound I remember. I don't know whether I cried; I don't think I felt anything at first. I think I felt the blood before the pain. I remember watching the river from the classroom window most of the time.

The Dark Room

I remember a punishment from a teacher. She locked me in a dark room, a storeroom attached to our classroom, or maybe an unused toilet, full of dust and discarded things. It was so frightening in there. I cried and cried, banging on the door, and got beaten for it. It was the scariest thing that happened to me at school, and all for not doing my homework or not knowing an answer. I still don't understand why it had to be that way. It was one of the first and strongest punishments I ever received.

Crossing Alone

One day I had to get home from school by myself. Every day my mother came to fetch me, but that day I couldn't find her at the gate. I waited, hoping she was only late. Time passed, and no one came. Our school had no bus, only a small hand-pedalled rickshaw that carried maybe ten small children like me. The driver said he would drop me halfway, so I climbed in, still watching for my mother through the whole ride. He set me down halfway, and there I waited again, because I could not cross what lay ahead.

Before me was a wide stretch, a bamboo grove and a river spread over perhaps a hundred metres, the road so dense and winding it stayed dark even on a sunny day. Rumour said there were people who kidnapped children and sold them in India. I don't know how true it was, but it was true enough to us, and maybe our parents told us such things to keep us close. In that river, too, there were stories of people drowning. I stood at the

mouth of the mystery, confused. Schoolmates had already passed with their parents; one or two strangers went by, but I was too shy and frightened even to ask for help. I thought: if I wait, it will only grow darker; if I walk in, I may never come out. It was a choice between the fear in the story and the truth of the road.

At last I decided to cross. I picked up my bag, tightened it on my back, tied my loose shoe, pulled up my trousers, and ran. Ran for my life. Ran full of anger and frustration and tears and courage and hope. Ran to survive. Ran to see the truth. Ran to pass. Ran to independence, to confidence, to win. I cried loudly, my ears ringing, my nose running, and as I went deeper everything seemed to freeze, sound, air, vision, all of it. My body went numb, my legs moved on their own, and I stopped hearing my own crying. Something changed in there. I still know that feeling of zoning out, of reaching another dimension. Then the light grew ahead, and an opening, and I began to come back.

In the distance I saw my mother riding a bicycle. I had crossed. I stopped, and cried even harder, throwing down my bag and shoes, shouting at her, fighting her, why didn't you come, why, why. She told me I was very brave and very strong, and she was sorry for being late. I was so happy to see her. She cleaned me, calmed me, and took me home. That day left a deep mark on how I still see life. She could not be beside me every moment; no one can. We have to be ready, always, to stand alone. To explore alone. Everyone in this world is free.

Tied Hands

I remember not being allowed to take part in the school sports day, maybe we were too small. I watched the students run after sweets hung on a rope, trying to catch them with their mouths while their hands were tied behind their backs. I sat imagining myself doing it, thinking that if it were me, I would swallow every sweet in the blink of an eye. That memory stays with me because I felt their struggle in my own body. I was twitching my own hands and body in the audience, suffocating with them, imagining my hands tied.

I can relate this to what is happening in the world today. We are forced inside our own system to be dumb, unhealthy, greedy, possessive, controlled. That is the suffocation I feel. The beautiful fruits of nature and of the future are right there, and we are tied up in a rat-race of show-off, control, and dominance, straining toward them with our hands bound.

The Cardboard

One year it was time for the final exam, and I was excited without understanding what an exam was. To me it only meant we didn't have to carry heavy bags and books, we went to school for just an hour or two with a geometry box and a board, and afterward there would be months of holidays. That was all "exam" meant to me, I cared nothing for passing, grades, or moving up a class.

So, excited, I asked my parents to buy me a paper clipboard. They said no, flatly. I fought them, and in the end they cut a piece of cardboard from a box in our shop and shaped it into a

board for me. I was sad, angry, and ashamed. I carried it to school anyway. I saw the other children with their proper clipboards, some had none either, but I noticed only the ones who did. When friends came and asked what I was carrying, I said, "Oh, I brought this to play," and we threw it like a frisbee until the bell rang. Then we went in, and I wrote my exam without it, and it was fine. There were many like me, without clipboards.

Why was I ashamed? I don't fully know. Maybe I was comparative, competitive, even jealous. I didn't understand why others had it and I didn't, and I didn't yet understand money at all. Looking back, my dad was strict about buying useless things; he lived a minimal life. And really, I didn't need the clipboard. It was thirty minutes of writing, and there were more important things in the family. That is all I remember of that school. The next year I moved on, and not a single teacher or friend from there stayed in my memory. It is sad how they are lost to time.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Journey Home

Every year we went back to Bhojpur, Mom, Dad, my little brother, my cousin Bishnu, and me, to our roots and our joint family, to celebrate Dashain and Tihar. After all, these are festivals of family. We took a bus to Dharan before the sun rose, then a bus to Hile, then walked to Pakhribas, eating on the way at a spring, and kept climbing up and down the hills. It took two days to reach our home in Bhojpur. When my brother and I grew tired, Mom, Dad, and Bishnu carried us.

On the way we sheltered in family lodges, and in festival time it was wonderful, many families returning home, porters carrying goods to Bhojpur Bazar in their doko baskets, music and food and shared stories among travellers. In the sleeping places people gathered in numbers, from different cultures and trades, and everyone cooked and drank and shared their laughter. We slept on rice-straw mats and whatever the host family gave, and they were always welcoming. There was a saying: *travellers and guests are avatars of the gods*. I miss that culture. Modern development has corrupted much of it.

I remember my cousin pinching me out of tiredness when he had to carry me. I remember my dad whistling and making sounds, saying he was calling the wind, it would grow so hot walking all day under open sky, up and down the hills with our bags, and we all followed his “calling wind,” and I believed it worked. I remember offering pigeons and chickens to the forests and rivers, a way of pleasing nature for a safe journey home. Once, arriving near a waterfall, I was so excited I ran ahead with both arms out, brushing the lush green plants, and my hands were stung by nettles. My joy turned to pain and tears, and every traveller laughed at the sight of me.

The next morning we would set off again before sunrise and reach home around noon, and it was deeply satisfying. The family knew we were coming and began at once to feed us, meat, festival food, fruit. We brought salt, sugar, flour, and factory goods as gifts. We were city children now, but we would go with our cousins to cut grass in the jungle and graze the goats and do all the village work. I loved doing puja with my grandparents. I slept sometimes with my middle uncle, sometimes with Grandpa, sometimes with Grandma. I drank a little alcohol in the celebrations, watched the aunts churn butter, and loved wandering the villages for meat and food. On the final day, tika day, we would walk three or four hours to my mother’s home for the same family celebration, stay a day, and return. This journey I waited for the whole year. Some stretches were heavenly, some were hot and hard and rocky. It was life, some of it the pain of walking, some the bliss of rest and food and stories. It made us stronger. It was a kind of pilgrimage: our journey, every year, back home.

A Place Like Heaven

There were two ways to Bhojpur. One I have already described; the other was a shorter bus ride and a longer but easier walk, always alongside a river, and it took two full days on foot. Once, returning after the celebrations, tired, on the second day of walking, one of my parents carrying me on their back, it was already dark and we walked by battery light. In the distance I saw thousands of oil lamps lit, horses calling, bells ringing, priests chanting mantras. The smell of the lamps hung over the whole forest, and it was dreamy, all of it wrapped in smoke on the hillside. From afar it looked like heaven.

We came closer and closer, growing impatient to reach it, to rest and eat and share the night. Years later, near my teens, this memory began to feel like a dream. I would ask my parents whether there were really places like that in the hills, rivers, horses, temples, music, fire, and they kept saying they didn't remember taking me anywhere like it. I asked and asked, and they said the same thing, until one day we reached that very place again, in a similar hour, and they too remembered: they had walked this path with me once, when I was very, very small. They were shocked that I remembered, because it meant I had been so young. I don't know why this memory stayed so strong, or what it means, or how it shaped me. Some memories fade, it is a wonder how the brain works. I wonder how many places, faces, friends, and promises I have forgotten, and why some memories choose to stay. It feels important to keep them. I wonder if it is tied to some larger force in nature.

CHAPTER SIX

The Locked Room

Around the age of ten, though I am not sure, I was introduced to lust and to sex by an older girl in the village. We were playing hide-and-seek, and she took me into a room to hide and locked the door. After a while she took off her clothes and mine, and she began to guide me, asking me to do things with her. She tried different ways; I was very small for her. Once there were other boys too, three of us in turn. Once her brother came home and knocked, and I was scared to death, but she, fierce as always, scolded him away, and we went on.

I don't know how I understood it then. We were hiding from the grown-ups, and to me it felt like exploring the wonders of life. People today would call it abuse, and they would be right to. I hold a more complicated understanding of my own life, and I have chosen to call it an experience to learn from. In the years after, I kept exploring, with girls and with boys, sometimes abused, sometimes abusing, and I carried it all as a hard education. That older girl was surely only passing on what someone had shown her too soon, a wound moving through children who did not choose it, and I hold nothing against her now. I have made my peace with all of it, and if I tell it plainly, it is only so that another child carrying the same silence might feel a little less alone.

Later I tried to express my desire to a mother of two children, in a way she did not welcome. She was a striking woman who had caught my mind and my imagination, and I didn't know how to carry what I felt. When I acted on it, she was upset, and the incident spread through my home and community like a virus. I was deeply ashamed, and confused: it was a girl who had introduced me to these things, and now I was the one being shamed for feeling them. No one spoke openly about any of it. If I asked my parents about sex, they must have silenced me, or turned my mind aside with a story of the gods, or planted it in me as taboo, as something evil, or told me I would understand when I was older. But inside, I knew how it had felt. I knew it was real. I knew I had wanted more of those feelings.

So I grew shy of expressing myself to anyone. I shut my doors. It felt like a crime, and I carried it like a trauma for a long time, until around 2011. Until then I could not accept love even when it was offered; I did not know how to act toward those who wanted to be close to me. It took me somewhere dark. And yet, perhaps because of my shyness and the depth in my eyes, I drew admirers and lovers early, and still do. In the end, I was becoming hard for my parents to handle, and they decided to send me to the hostel.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Father's School

I don't remember much of Gayatri Vidya Peeth, my second school. A few friends have reminded me that we were there together, but nothing else remains. It turned out the place was really a hostel, running a kindergarten to prepare children for Suryodaya English Medium School, where I would end up next, and it became my hostel for years to come.

Suryodaya was a famous, big school, a Christian Catholic school run by Fathers and Sisters, celebrated for its discipline and its teaching. People called it Father's school. The whole village talked about us moving there, and we children were excited. Many of us made the move together, so one day my mother, some village aunties, and a crowd of children went for the entrance.

When I reached that school I was blown away, it was big to the point of frightening, for a boy from a wooden house in a village. Clean, well-off people from the town; Sisters, Fathers, teachers, everything belonged to a different world from mine. My parents registered us, and then the drama began. They wouldn't let my mother into the classroom. Teachers called me in, and I fought, crying and refusing to go in alone, holding onto my mother's clothes while the teachers pulled and she tried to loosen my grip. That scene still stays with me. Mom told me later that I didn't even sit the entrance exam, yet they

took me into Nursery. There was no LKG or UKG then, straight to Nursery, then classes one through ten. I spent eleven years here, until the day I was suspended in class nine.

The Potato Clock

One morning Mom was taking me to school on her bicycle when I saw a clock in a shop, a “potato clock,” a toy clock for children, green, or maybe many colours, but my eyes caught the green one. I asked her to buy it. She paid no mind, bought something else, and pulled me back to the bicycle; we were late for school.

So I began another of my performances, insisting, fighting, dragging her back toward the shop. There were people all around. She kept pulling me away, angry that day, and we had a big fight. I started hitting her and rolling on the ground in my uniform and bag, and she hit me back where I lay. I rolled and cried harder, until the tears and the dirt mixed and covered my whole uniform, and I was unfit for school. I remember her giving up on me, leaving me there on the ground, and turning the bicycle around. Maybe we went home for more beatings, and more love. I still didn’t understand money. We had a shop, after all. Maybe I simply didn’t want to go to school and was making excuses. I only knew I was confused about why money stood between me and everything I wanted.

A Punishment Without Reason

Once, on a break, I was walking alone to the toilet when someone grabbed my collar from behind, lifted me, and dragged me ten or fifteen metres. He took up a stick and beat me so hard that I wet my trousers, striking me again and again. When he was done he shoved me away, and I walked on, wondering what had happened. Students stood watching, some perhaps thinking I had done something wrong. He was a Nepali teacher. I never learned the reason. No one talked about it, and I never asked. I chose to stay in the confusion. I could never understand him, or what he did. For a long time it sat in me as an injustice, and then I let it go. Perhaps he was carrying something that day that had nothing to do with me, some pain of his own that found the nearest small body. I do not excuse it, and yet I understand now that hurt people hurt others, and understanding is where my anger finally goes to rest.

The First Foreigners

There were two white foreigners at our school once, who came to spend time with our class. I don't remember why. We asked questions and they answered, and I was amazed by their skin and their beauty, and confused about whether they were even human beings from this earth, they talked and moved so differently. We had seen such people in the movies, but in the flesh it was overwhelming. We asked about their skin, their country, their food, and then I asked the question I never forgot: was the wrestling on TV real, and were the English movies real? They told me it was all fake, "those are dra-

mas and actors; they don't really get hurt, they don't die." I felt betrayed, because I had believed it, especially the wrestling. I never watched it the same way again.

The Dance

Once a teacher asked me to dance in front of the class, and I froze, too shy, too scared, no guts and no moves. She kept pushing, saying she wouldn't stop until I danced. It felt like a lifetime, standing there with the whole class watching. At last I moved my body a little and sang whatever came out of my mouth, *Rato tika nidhar ma, talka-talkayo*, and then stood frozen again. I don't remember whether the bell saved me or she let me go.

From then on I was never comfortable with crowds or performance. I loved singing and playing music, but I could no longer perform. It took a great deal to heal, and I healed only much later, by teaching children, dancing with them, slowly opening up again.

Revenge

Whether or not it was the reason, that same teacher's son was bullied by me and a friend. We bit him, and blood came from an old wound on his leg, and he told his mother. The next day we got it back, beaten in front of the whole class. Revenge is dangerous; the cycle only continues, and no good comes of it. There is only loss to follow.

My Brother

My little brother went to a different school, Motherland, and people used to joke that I was my father's boy so I went to "Fatherland" school, and he was my mother's boy so he went to Motherland. He joined my school late. Once he was caught taking a pencil from another student, or had forgotten his homework, and he came to me, scared and crying. I could do nothing, I couldn't go to his class and reason with the teachers, and it broke me to see him suffer. So I pulled up some dubu, the holy grass, prayed over it, and pressed it into his palm. I told him to hold it, that it would protect him, and I wiped his tears and sent him off. He kept it clutched in his pocket, and later he told me nothing had happened, that he wasn't punished. I was very happy.

Medals

I took part in the school sports. I was in the Blue House. I won the hundred-metre race several times in a row, first place; I won the relay; I scored goals in football. I was physically fit and I loved sport, and I was good at table tennis too. Whatever else school took from me, it gave me this: on the field, I knew exactly who I was.

PART THREE

The Hostel Years

Two hundred boys behind high walls, a country at war, and a child learning that the day and the night can belong to two different worlds, and that a person can carry both without breaking.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Two Hundred Boys

I failed my first year in Nursery. I was naughty for my parents, and home was far, so they decided to send me to a hostel. It was one of the most reputed hostels in town, run by a retired British-army man, a friend of the founding Father of the school I was to attend. Around two hundred students lived there together, in huge buildings and halls and dormitories, with a food forest, playgrounds, coconut and lemon and banana and guava trees, farm machines, tractors, mills, biogas, a laundry house, everything. It was organized and well managed, strict, and the best in town.

I do not remember my first day. The head auntie appointed a boy to look after me and guide me until I learned the rules and the timetable, and he became my best friend, even naughtier than me, and together we learned to get the best out of hostel life. He was another son of the British army, both his parents in the UK, a rich, pampered child left behind, like me. We had a blast; he taught me to fight back against bullies, and I taught him to study. Even in a place I did not choose, life gave

me a brother to stand beside. I have come to see that this is how it always is: wherever we are set down, if we look, there is someone to hold onto.

Still, I kept asking myself why my parents did not visit, why they had left me there. Whom was I to ask for food, to sleep beside, to play with, to trust, to celebrate with, to rely on? I felt lost, and I used to think they did not want me, did not love me, that they were too busy with the revolution. But my little brother was still at home, and I would wonder how much difference one more child could make. I had many questions and no one to ask them. Only much later did I understand that their absence was not the absence of love; it was love spent on something larger than us, and a scarcity they were trying, in their own hard way, to raise us inside of.

Looking around, I saw the distance between me and the others. Most were from British-army families, some from England, Hong Kong, Brunei, Kathmandu, Pokhara, India. They celebrated birthdays with the whole hostel, handing out sweets and biscuits, and they had better clothes, Walkmans, CD players, toy guns, Game Boys, even pocket TVs, and came back from holidays with stocked food and stories of parks and zoos and museums and trains and aeroplanes. I had nothing to share but my village life, and among them I was nervous and shy and ashamed. I wondered how they had everything, where it came from; they said “our parents,” but my parents worked hard too, day and night, and had a shop and a farm and friends, so how? I was jealous, and I even began to blame my parents, and I could tell none of this to anyone. It is a strange thing, that early ache of comparison; it took me years

to see that what I lacked in things I was being given in something else, in the strength that grows only in those who do without.

We had good times too. Every Saturday there was a cleaning day, and we would walk the city in a line in the morning; we watched movies on weekends, held sports days and farewells and welcome celebrations and bingo, where I once won a bar of bathing soap. The hostel owner had a farm and brought us seasonal fruit, and there were three school hostels that competed in sports. Those were exciting days, and I hold them dear, because a childhood is never only its wounds; it is also its small, bright, ordinary joys, and I have learned to remember both.

CHAPTER NINE

When the Lights Went Out

Hostel life is a strange thing. By day it was games and study and laughter and food; by night it turned into something else. As soon as the lights went out, a darkness came out of people. A good person became cruel; leaders became leeches; protectors became dominators; captains became corrupt. Grown boys forced the younger ones to massage them at night. Some forced themselves on us. Some

ganged up and beat us in the dark. Some crept to the girls' side to watch them bathe. Some stole our food, our toys, our money. Some teachers gathered with seniors and local gang boys to smoke and take out their frustration on us. The day belonged to one world, and the night to a secret one.

Against My Will

 ne night in particular, an older boy forced himself on me. It was painful and it was disgusting, and he kept his hand over my mouth so I could not cry out, threatening to beat me if I made a sound. I cried the whole time. He was big and strong, and I was helpless, and there was no one I could tell. For a long while I carried it as a wound, in silence, the way a child carries what he has no words for.

I have thought about how to hold this, and I will tell you honestly where I have arrived, not to excuse anything, but because it is the only place I could go on living from. I hold no hatred for that boy now. He was himself a child of that same darkness, most likely doing to me what had been done to him, a wound passing itself down in the dark. I do not say what happened was right; it was not, and no child should ever carry it. But I refuse to let it own the rest of my life. I have chosen to take it as a lesson, a truth, a piece of my own reality, and to keep walking, and to keep smiling most of the time. That is not forgetting; it is refusing to let a thing that once made me a victim keep me one. If there is any use in my having lived it, it is that I now recognize that pain in others, in the difficult children I would later teach, and I know how to sit beside it without judgment.

At my grandmother's place there was a custom of telling moral and religious stories at night before sleep, and one of them was, "Whatever happens, happens for a reason," and it is left to each person how to understand it and store it and use it later. I have kept both the dark and the good side of that idea, holding a balance and drawing on it as each moment needs, and much later, at Vipassana, I finally learned to use it fully, to let the past be the past.

I missed my parents then, and my home, and everything a family offers, protection and comfort and guidance and a place in the world. I would wonder in silence when the sun would come, why they had not come to see me, why they would not take me away. I complained of the evil things to my parents, and I remember being told the person had been punished and it would never happen again, and yet it continued as soon as the sun went down. In the end I had to face it alone, and though no child should have to, that aloneness taught me a self-reliance that has never left me. I do not thank the darkness for it, but I do thank the boy I was, who kept getting up.

One teacher made me do his personal errands, his vegetable shopping and small tasks, because I came from a poor family, calling for me even when I was nowhere near, and I hated it and cried a lot. And yet, looking back, that same man forced me to study well. He saw me losing my roots, being pulled toward wealth and a fake face, and, coming from a background like mine, I believe he was trying in his rough way to protect and warn and teach me. I have chosen to believe the kindness under the hardness, because I have learned that most cruelty is only love that was never taught how to speak.

There was good routine too, morning exercise every day, and in the evenings I joined karate, though I never wore any belt but white. On holidays the seniors would gather us in the TV hall in a circle and make us younger ones fight one another like a cage match, sometimes until we bled or cried or ran, which only brought more punishment. And yet afterward we would wash together, and sometimes cry together, and forgive each other, and be friends again, and in that strange rhythm I first learned that even those who hurt you can become your brothers when the fear passes. I was strong and athletic and brave, and I would not back down from a fight, and still I was a victim at night, for no one escaped, or at least I did not. Slowly, what I feared and hated began to become me. I learned it and adopted it, and I became everything, liar and thief and bully and protector by turns, and by day I was a good student, obedient and charming and kind. It was a game of survival, and I do not hide it from you, because the boy who became all of those things is the same one who later spent his life trying to build a world where no child would have to.

CHAPTER TEN

Games and Fears

Not all of it was darkness. For a while it was the age of the toy magazine gun, and everyone brought one, and at night we split the sleeping hall into two rows, built our fortresses and teams, and went to war, and it was fun, and in the morning some woke with bumps and small wounds. Then it upgraded to slingshots and paper bullets, and one morning the whole room was covered in paper balls, and we were all punished in assembly. Even inside those walls, children will make joy out of whatever they are given; it is one of the most stubborn and beautiful things about us.

Once everyone planned a picnic on a holiday, and a Sister asked if I wanted to join, and I was excited and said yes, then realized I had no proper clothes. So I washed my favourite old clothes the whole night and wore them still wet in the morning, and when I reached the meeting place, everyone was asleep; the picnic had been cancelled. I felt sad and relieved at once, because of my clothes. It is a small memory, and yet it holds the whole shape of that time, the wanting to belong, and the quiet shame, and the odd mercy of being spared. I learned early to live by myself, to make my own company, to trust care-

fully, to be ready for changing friendships and broken promises, and to figure out life through silence and observation and adapting, staying always a little watchful. It made me lonely, but it also made me able to stand anywhere.

One day at lunchtime I took a grass path and saw a small snake ahead. I turned left, and there was another; I turned back, and there was another; every way I turned there was a snake, and it happened so fast that the power to move left me. I could not move or think, and I saw friends in the distance but could not call them, my voice would not come, and I stood there paralyzed. At last they noticed me acting strangely and asked what I was doing, and even then I could not answer, could not say the snakes had surrounded me, until they went their way and I ran. I brought friends back with sticks and stones, but the snakes were gone. It was the deepest fear I have ever felt, the kind that freezes you where you stand, and I think of it now as my first teacher of fear itself, the thing that showed me how the body can betray the will, and how, still, the fear passes, and you run, and you live.

When the film *Josh* came out, we were so taken with it that we formed gangs, and I led the Scorpion Gang. We pretended to fight, and sometimes it turned real. Once my little brother was ambushed for being the Scorpion leader's brother, and he came crying that they had bitten him, and I took him to them and told him to hit the boy back; but the scared little one could not, so I did it for him. That is how it was, bullying and being bullied by turns, and I am not proud of the bully I could be, but we had our fun in those roles, and I have made my peace with that child too. I made my whole family inside those walls from

whatever I could find, until at some point I began to think the hostel was the entire world and outsiders were strangers. We were poor in the ways that showed: how rarely my parents visited, how little we could buy. A few of us were like that, and we learned to steal from those who had more, to lie and trade and tell stories to get what we wanted, and I did not understand how my parents could work so hard and still have so little, or whether they had money and withheld it. I know now that they were revolutionaries who wanted me to learn from scarcity, and that they were wise and brave enough to train me even in that hard way. As the saying goes, no one grows in comfort, and I have come to be grateful for a childhood that refused to make me soft.

Every year, at the start of winter, the hostel took us on a picnic, usually to Letang, and it was one of the most wonderful times we had. The night before, we were too excited to sleep. In the morning we boarded the bus to a beautiful spot of hills and clean rivers, and we swam and ate well and held sports and quizzes and danced and sang. I loved the swimming most, though I could not really swim; the seniors would dam the river with big stones to raise the water. Most of all I loved that open nature, no walls and no borders, just hills and rivers and stones and plants, where I could see far into the distance, and something in me could finally breathe. Even then, before I had any words for it, nature was the one place that gave me back to myself.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Moving Houses

While all this was happening to me and my brother, our parents kept moving from place to place. Every time I came home on vacation, they were somewhere new. From Kherkhera they moved to Campus Mode, then to Damak Choke, each time a bigger shop and restaurant, though we still slept in the shop at night, and I think our family was making a decent living by then. There is a particular loneliness in a child who never quite knows which walls are home, and I carried it quietly, and I think it is part of why, all my life, I have wanted so badly to build one true place that stays.

In those places I kept exploring my own body and desires, with boys and girls both, in the confused, unguided way of a child who has been shown too much too early and told nothing. Once I was with a girl in the toilet when my parents came home, and I stayed silent until they were busy. Once I went into the room of a bold, striking woman, a mother of two who wore make-up and expensive clothes and intimidated me, and I found her underthings and began to play with them, and she caught me and asked why, and I stood there voiceless and ashamed. I do not know if it reached my parents, but from then on I pulled away from girls, and it grew harder and harder to express myself. It was a girl who had first taught me these things, and girls, again, who exposed me to shame, and

the two got tangled in me for years. Even in the hostel, when older sisters tried to hug or kiss me, I would freeze with guilt. Later I had girlfriends who gave every sign, some who even brought condoms, and still I could not so much as kiss them; it took me years to break free of that. I tell this plainly, without shame now, because I think a great deal of human suffering hides in exactly these silences, and if my honesty helps even one person feel less alone in theirs, then the telling is worth it.

My father was strict and quick to beat me. Once my cousins visited and I took ten rupees from the shop to buy peanuts to share, and when he found out he threw me to the ground by my neck. I cried to my mother that I was afraid to study with him, because he beat me whenever I got an answer wrong; he tutored the local children too. I will not pretend those beatings did not hurt, or that they were right, for I do not believe a child is taught by fear. And yet I have forgiven my father completely. He was a man carrying more than he could hold, raising sons between a revolution and a breaking home, with his own unhealed wounds, and he did the only thing his own hard life had taught him. A father has many roles, and he played the ones he knew. I hold no blame; I only wish, for every child, gentler teachers, and I have tried to be one.

Once film actors came to our cold-store restaurant in a red jeep, and the whole neighbourhood crowded in; my mother wanted me to meet them, but I ran and hid until they left. We lived on the highway, and there I saw my first road deaths, a child who put his head out of a bus, a man trying to cross, and I do not think I understood death then; I could not grasp that a person would simply never walk among us again. At Damak

Choke there were more shops and machines, an ice factory, an ice-cream factory, a printing press, workshops, photo studios, and on holidays I would stand for hours watching people run their machines, lost in the making of things, until someone came to fetch me, while my friends did their family and vacation things. Once, playing with paper at the printing press, I gave myself a deep cut, and I was amazed that paper could cut so deep; I think that gave me a lasting love of physics, of how the world is put together. My father had a laptop, and I loved watching the logo as it started up, though I understood nothing of his work; my mother says he was among the first to open a computer institute in Damak, before a dispute with his partners made him give it up. I see now that I came from questioning, restless people, and that my own hunger to understand how everything works was theirs before it was mine.

An uncle used to come to our restaurant, a British-army man, and every single time, for years, he asked me the same questions: How are you? What did you do today? What do you want from life? Who are you? What is your purpose? How will you achieve it? I would run when I saw him, but he always found me. A stranger and a customer, and yet I think he planted something in me that never stopped growing, for those are the very questions I have spent my whole life trying to answer, and now ask of everyone I meet. We never know which passing person is quietly shaping us. Once I found the courage to bunk the hostel and bring my best friend home for thukpa and momos, running back before anyone noticed. Once I grew curious about the light socket and put my finger in it, and the shock only excited me; I kept trying to touch and

pull away before it could catch me, until my mother caught me instead and switched it off. I only wanted to understand where it came from. Was it in the walls? Was it God? I laugh at that boy now, and I love him, for he never stopped wanting to know.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Bus, and the Haunted House

One vacation my father took my brother and me to Kathmandu to visit our maternal uncle, a doctor. We booked a night bus, and Dad bought us each a fruit drink; I finished mine, and my brother was still holding his. We were asleep when, suddenly, a bang. People were shouting and thrown to the floor, and I had hit my head but felt no pain in the shock of it. Our bus had struck a parked tractor-trolley, and the left side, where we sat, was crushed up to the door, and people climbed out through the driver's door and the windows. On the ground I saw people without hands or legs, blood spreading and catching the light, a boy crying "Mama, mama" while his uncle gave him water, bodies lying motionless in the dark. The driver had run off; they said he had been drinking at every stop. That was my first journey to the capital, and my first true sight of how

thin the line is between an ordinary night and the end of one. I have never forgotten it, and I think it is part of why I hold every moment as something borrowed.

We reached my uncle's quarters and visited Swayambhu, Pashupatinath, Godavari, Ratna Park, and Rani Pokhari, amazed at the big buildings and the traffic. I asked my brother how he felt about the accident, and he said, "I was worried I had lost my fruit drink," and I have loved him for that answer ever since; a child's heart holds only what it can hold. We played with the local children and beat them at their own games, and felt strong and fast, and I thought even then that this is what the city and its comfort do to the body, softening it, and I came home more certain that we were not meant to live so far from the earth. Then we returned to Damak, to school and hostel again, and by the next time I came home my parents had moved once more.

The Haunted House

The next house belonged to another British-army man, then in jail for killing his wife, burning her alive in a jute sack. After the murder everyone had fled the place, calling it cursed, and it stood empty, a big house with land and a wooden house behind it, in a mixed community of Gurkha families, Muslims, and Indian Hindus. My mother asked the owner if we could stay, and he agreed, and she cleaned away the burnt remains with her own hands and moved us in. Once she did, other families returned too, and we shared the house with a Muslim family and an Indian family, more than twenty children when we all gathered, and my oldest uncle's place

was only two hundred metres away. My mother was never afraid of what others fled; she saw a shelter where others saw a curse, and I think I inherited that from her, the refusal to be ruled by fear or superstition.

More deaths followed there, a newborn from the Muslim family, a man who took his own life, and then his wife, who hanged herself, some said out of guilt, and people believed the place was truly haunted. My family did not care. And because my parents kept moving, I once got lost in my own town, riding the bicycle I had just learned, excited, until I no longer knew where I was, and a man saw how frightened I was and asked where I lived, and I described my house as best I could, and he walked me home, where my mother gave him tea before he left. Even in a town full of ghosts and gossip, a stranger's simple kindness carried a lost boy home, and I have never forgotten that either; the world is crueler than we wish, and kinder than we fear, both at once.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Kali, and the Books of Code

In front of our place lived a beautiful girl from a Gurkha family, whom everyone called Kali. She was the talk of the town, a fine dancer, and boys came from all around to flirt

with her. One day, sitting alone outside our shop, a boy ran up with a message, “She says she likes you,” and ran off, and I smiled and walked back inside and thought nothing of it. But she began calling my name from her window, then on our landline, and it caught my attention, and for a short while we walked around like lovers, holding and kissing hands, until I had to return to the hostel, and the story ended in a kiss.

The next vacation I learned she was with another man, and it broke my heart, and I had no strength to quarrel or even to speak with her; life was simply like that. There was an older sister in our shared house, desired by many men, and she came to my rescue. One night, as I sat angry by the phone wanting to call Kali, she explained to me what love means: never to possess, never to force anger on a girl, that love is freedom, that every person is free to choose how and with whom they live. She told me that at our age it does not matter, that I should accept things with a smile and move on, that I was young and the world was wide, that I should explore and try and see. I listened to that wisdom, drank it in as a keen learner does, and felt lighter and humbler for it, and understood, young as I was, that we are all free to choose. That lesson, that love is freedom and never possession, became one of the guiding truths of my life, though it would take me many more years, and many mistakes, to truly live it. I will not pretend I was a saint in those days; I used to peek at that same sister from the rooftop and fantasize about her, taught by the same neighbour boy who taught me to steal cigarettes and smoke. A boy is a tangle of longing and confusion, and I was no different, and I tell it honestly so that you know the man

who later spoke of harmony was first a child who had to find it the hard way. Kali went back and forth, with me when I was home, with others when I left, and she even brought me condoms once, but I could not, still bound by the old wound; and yet I loved her, and missed her from the hostel.

The Books of Code

At school, computers were taught from around class two, and I chased the subject up the years, drawn to computers and the internet and games. Around then the hostel gave me and my brother two new boys to look after, brothers from another Gurkha family, and we grew very close, the four of us. The older one, my age, was a little different in his nature, and I have always had a gift for connecting with such people, or perhaps he is the one who developed that gift in me. He was kind and straight and simple, and if anyone troubled me he would beat them senseless; he loved me the way he lived, wholly. I confess I sometimes took advantage of how naive he was, and I am not proud of it, and I say so plainly, because honesty about my own smallness is the only thing that earns the right to speak of anything larger.

One day we heard of AI, artificial intelligence, and set out to learn how to build one. We listed the books it would need and found nothing in our school books, and forgot about it. Then, days later, that friend called me to his house, and there were more than ten books, each thicker than our hands could hold, thousands of pages. I asked where they had come from, and he said he had gone to India with his mother and bought them. We opened them, excited, and found not a single picture, only

black-and-white code and arrows and descriptions with no beginning and no end, and we understood nothing, and asked the repair shops and maybe a teacher, and then let it go. No one could guide us; no one cared for the dream of two boys. Maybe we were born in the wrong place, he more than me. He was a rare, wild soul who never fit the ordinary world, and I was the one place he felt safe. When I look back, I grieve not only for him but for how many gifted, unusual minds this world quietly wastes because it has no room for them, and I think that grief is part of why I built what I built.

He became a self-taught painter later, and would vanish from Nepal and reappear in strange places, lost in this world. I tried many times to bring him to live with me on my project, but his parents always came and took him home; they trusted me so deeply that whenever he disappeared, they came to me first. We were family. But around 2025 he ended his life, somewhere in India. He had loved a girl who died of an illness, and then he followed her. He had called me only months before to tell me of her death, and I kept telling him to come and live with me, and he kept fearing his parents' world would take him back. I carry the ache of that call still, the sense that if the world had only had a place for him, he might have stayed. He will always remain in my heart, and every gentle, difficult soul I now try to keep close is, in some way, for him.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The War

This was the peak of the civil war, and here things grew rough. My family were communists, working in secret, while by day government spy-soldiers patrolled between two banks in the bazaar, one directly in front of our house. I did not understand the danger, or the need for secrecy; the soldiers used to show me their folding guns and grenades, and to this day I have never held a grudge against them, for they were only boys in uniform following orders, as caught in the machine as anyone. One day a group came on two motorbikes and opened fire on them; one fell, one was wounded, and one ran to our shop for backup. It happened so fast, the gunfire, people scattering, the whole street emptying in a moment, and the survivors fired a round into the sky and told everyone to go inside but us to keep our shop open. I felt sad for them, for all of them, the ones who fell and the ones who fired; even as a child, something in me could not take a side in the killing.

After that my brother was sent to the hostel with me, and my father and cousin began to disappear more often. Once the police came looking for my father, and my little brother told them, "I saw him go inside five minutes ago," then walked out casually and vanished; only later did I understand they were undercover police and that my father was hidden in the room, and they searched the whole house and found no one. My fath-

er was clever; I heard he helped build war strategy in the jungles and wrote books of the revolution, and my brother was a youth leader for the whole eastern district. I did not know then how large they loomed in that war; I only knew the fear that hung over our house like weather.

At some point my mother was captured by the government army, and I went to visit her in jail, the aunt taking us smuggling a message on cauliflower leaves. We could not meet in person; from the gate I could see only that she had grown thin and weak. We had brought food, and the guards made me eat it all first, testing for poison, for she was an important figure, taken only as a hostage, to torture the location of my father and brother out of her. She reached her hand through the bars toward us, hiding her bruises and her tears and the beatings of day and night, until she could bear no more and had to leave early. I did not have the words for it then, but I know now what I was seeing: a mother enduring the unbearable and still trying to spare her children the sight of her pain. That is the strongest thing I have ever witnessed, and it set the measure of courage for my whole life.

One birthday in the hostel I sat alone, hiding the day, wishing no one knew, because I had nothing to share. The gatekeeper called me, a visitor, and opened only the small eye-slot in the gate, and outside stood a man in a hat and a well-cut coat, long beard to his chest, long hair, black glasses, whom I could not recognize at first. He reached into his pocket, passed a round orange sweet through the gap, said, “Janma din ko subhakamana, chora,” happy birthday, son, and left. It was my father, moving between hiding places, risking his freedom to

press a single sweet through a slot in a gate to a boy he could not even embrace. It is my first memory of a birthday gift, and it remains one of the most precious things I own, for in it is the whole truth of him, that beneath the beatings and the absence there was a father who loved, and who came when he could not afford to come. When I forgive him everything, this is the moment I forgive him from.

My mother was released only when my father was caught in Bhojpur, surrounded and taken from his bed, betrayed by someone he knew. They covered his face and led him away on foot, and he was meant to go to court, but the armed police began marching him toward the jungle instead, which everyone understood. By luck, a lawyer was passing and called out to ask where they were going, and when they said, "To the court," he shouted, "Is that the way to court?" and they answered, "Sorry, we are new here," and the lawyer said, "I am coming too, let us go together." That is how my father is alive to this day. A stranger's single, brave question saved my father's life, and I never learned his name, and I have blessed him every day since; that is how much one person's courage can matter. Then my brother came to our school with his communist group and announced it would close, being an international Christian missionary school, and it stayed shut for months, once even bombed on a holiday when no one was there. Hoping to keep studying, we went with other families to India, to a bigger branch of the same school in Pedong, Kalimpong, passed the entrance, and came home to wait for the session to begin.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

A Family in Ruins

At last the war ended. The communists had won, peace was declared, and the country celebrated. Then came terrible news: our cousin Bishnu had been ambushed and killed by the army in his hiding place, given up by his own landlord. Even after peace, a cold war of scores went on. It was my first loss of someone close. We had grown up together, fighting and sleeping and grazing goats and counting passing vehicles side by side, and it hurt to know he would never carry me again, that I would never see him. A few days later came more news, that the whole family and the soldiers involved in his murder had themselves been killed, all of them, like a salute to my brother, and I understood then how important he must have been, how many eyes had watched over him. Revenge was sweet in the moment, and yet Bishnu was still gone, and other families were now grieving too, and looking back on all that war and politics I see clearly that it is not for me. It is stupid. Killing answers killing and answers nothing; the only thing that ever truly changes a world is not a bullet but a way of living, and I think my whole life since has been the slow learning of that one lesson.

My parents had been faithful and true to the revolution, sacrificing family and home and safety for it. My mother lived in a jail in Chandragadhi; my father in a jail in Bhojpur; my

cousin's uncle, who had lived with us, was murdered. They fought and won and threw out the king, and then they were not satisfied with what the victors became in power, corrupt, and untrue to everything they had promised, and out of frustration they left politics for good, having given everything and been paid in false promises. And when they tried to return to their families, they found the whole family already in ruin, everyone scattered. From this I take a lesson I have never let go of: that to change a nation, one must first work on the self, the family, and the community, and not the nation before the people. You must be careful where you spend your energy, and my parents, for all their courage, spent theirs on the largest thing while the smallest and dearest thing, us, quietly fell apart. I do not judge them for it. I only learned from it, and built the opposite.

When I came home now, I would find only my mother, with another man, or only my father, with another woman, and I caught them many times, and I was lost and confused. Once my father brought a woman and told my brother and me to call her mother, while our own mother was away, working as a nurse, or in jail, and that woman took her place and even took us to her home, far off in what I realize now was a Bhutanese refugee camp. Then my mother returned and fought her and chased her out, a huge fight the whole neighbourhood knew, and I think my father left after that. I will not sit in judgment of either of them. They were two wounded, exhausted people who had given a war everything and come home to ashes, and

they broke in the ways that broken people break. I have forgiven them both, fully, and more than that, I have come to honour them, because I understand now what they were carrying.

And my mother, whatever her wounds, was never truly of any party; she was human first. She nursed a distant cousin, a communist fighter shot almost to paralysis, back to health over months, and lied about it to protect her; and she did the same for a government soldier, shot and hidden and healed while my father was away, and later volunteered in a hospital in wartime, when others were too afraid to work. She would heal anyone, of any side, and I think everything gentle and fearless in me came from watching her do it.

Another birthday, we were all together and decided to celebrate. My parents brought an improvised cake, and we lit candles and sang, but before we had even finished eating, their argument turned into a bloody fight. Around then, one night, drinking milk before bed, my mother said, "What is in this? It tastes strange," and soon she was shaking, and we ran for a neighbour and rushed her to the hospital, where they made her vomit. We were never told the truth: she said my father had tried to poison her, and he said she was acting, and my brother and I were torn to pieces between them, puppets in their game. It was a very hard time, each of them pouring thoughts into our small minds. I have long since stopped trying to decide who was right that night; I have set the whole thing down. Two people I love were drowning, and they pulled at each other and at us the way drowning people do, and the only mercy I have found is to forgive it all and carry none of it forward. Later my father came back again, asking forgiveness,

with a plan to reunite the whole family, even to bring everyone from Bhojpur to live together in Damak, and he began selling property there and buying land here to do it. By then I had started smoking with school friends, stealing cigarettes from our own shop. It was too late for the family he dreamed of, and yet I honour the dream, because a man who keeps trying to mend what he has broken is still, to me, a good man.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Walls Come Down

When I was in grade eight, the hostel closed and became a college, and everything changed. I went home, and the world felt bigger, and I felt free and relieved, happy at last to live with my family. But it took a bad turn. Free among the shop and the money, I grew greedy and demanding; I began stealing money and buying perfumes, face washes, new shoes, all the things I had seen but never touched, and I forced my parents to buy me a computer and an internet connection, and a guitar. It is strange and humbling to see how quickly a child starved of things will gorge himself the moment they are within reach, and I have thought often since about how much of what we call greed is really just old hunger with no one to teach it enough.

By then the landlord's three children had come home, and they lived on the first floor while we lived below with our shop. The son had a huge influence among the youth and the gangs, and he had built a music practice hall that drew the metal and rock lovers, and slowly I was pulled in too. A neighbour boy who drove a rickshaw taught me most of the bad things, to steal cigarettes and drink and stalk girls, with his crazy fantasies and dirty mind. I do not blame him; he was only passing on what he had, as we all do, and I was a willing student. We are so shaped by whoever happens to stand nearest us at the right age, which is exactly why I came to believe, with my whole life, that the deepest work of all is to build good environments and good company around the young.

But there was light in that house too. My mother and father had taken up yoga and meditation, at a place a few minutes' walk away, in the days when Baba Ramdev's free movement was spreading, and they became so devoted they qualified as teachers, and they forced me awake early to practise with them. I hated waking early, and I thought it pointless, and yet in later life that very practice became my daily routine and my saviour; it healed me. So often the thing we resent most as children turns out to be the gift that saves us, and I have learned to be slow to reject what my elders hand me, even when I cannot yet see its use. My father also taught me to iron and fold clothes properly, which I had never had to do in the hostel, and because I loved to dress well for school with my

few clothes, I learned it gladly, a gentle lesson from a hard man, and I treasure that gentleness the more for how rare it was.

Not every lesson was gentle. Near our shop was a photo studio, where I loved to watch them film weddings and develop photographs from film, and I watched them for hours, close with them. Then one day the owner took me into his room, sat me down, and asked outright, “Where is the camera you stole?” I was stunned; I did not know what he meant, and when I could not answer he began to slap me and demand the camera, and I cried that I had not taken it. It cut me deeply. I had stolen money from my parents, yes, and taken back things in the hostel from those who took mine, but I had never stolen from others, and I was the quietest, most humble child there, and to be beaten for something I had not done, by someone I trusted, wounded me in a way I had not imagined. I understand now why it hurt so much more than the honest punishments: it was the injustice of it, being condemned for a thing I had not done. That day taught me, young, how it feels to be wrongly judged, and I made a quiet vow I did not even know I was making, never to do that to another, always to ask before I accuse, to look for the truth of a person before I decide what they are. Of all the lessons of those hostel years, that may be the one I have kept most faithfully.

PART FOUR

Restless Years

*Shops and journals, guitars and gangs, love
and drugs and running away, and the night
that ended in a police cell and a mother's for-
giveness.*

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Watching the World Work

Near our place was a beauty parlour, the most famous and successful in town, and its girls came to our shop for food and tea, and sometimes we carried tea across to them. They were bold and beautiful, and I do not know why, but I was so shy I could hardly look at them; I had my fantasies, and maybe that is what made me shyer still. Once my mother took me there to cut my hair, though I did not want to go, and while they cut it they found lice and laughed, “My God, you have an elephant in your jungle.” I was so embarrassed I never went back to cut my hair there again. The owner had two daughters, and the elder was born around the same time as me, and my mother and the owner used to tease that the two of us would marry one day. But they were clean and cute and beautiful, and I thought them far out of my league, and I was too shy even to talk to them.

There was a television repair shop near us too, and I loved my time there, spending hours just watching them work. Later we bought our first television from that place, and because of the shop we kept changing it over the years. It was small but good enough, and I watched endless English movies

and cartoons on it, and it was there that my brother introduced me to *One Piece*, which I still watch to this day. There was a bicycle shop nearby as well, where I watched them repair bicycles and learned much of my own riding, helping out here and there. That was the truth of me: I simply loved watching people work, whatever the trade, losing myself in the making of things.

The Burned Journals

At school one English teacher taught us to keep journals, and I loved that assignment and wrote everything about my days in mine, and I truly loved the writing. I kept it safe, but one day, somehow, my father read it, and he called me into the room and began asking what I was doing with my life and what I was writing, and out of nowhere he started beating me, hard. I grew so angry that I ran to the kitchen, grabbed a khukuri, and shouted that I would cut him, until my mother came running and took it from my hand and started shouting at me, I do not know what, while I stood there crying and complaining to her. It was a useless beating and scolding. I burned every journal I had written and swore never to write again.

It hurt me deeply, not the exposure itself but that someone would dig into my private life and blame and beat me for it. Everyone has a life, a hidden layer, a pattern of self-exploration, and no third party has the right to sneak into it and punish you for what they find. It broke my heart, and I stopped writing for a long time, afraid that someone would read me and judge me again; it took a great deal to heal from that, and only now do I love to write once more. The strange thing is

that our English teacher read all our journals and never once judged us or spoke of them; he kept his promise, and we trusted him like a friend and a guide. My father did the opposite. And yet it was not truly his fault. He was my father, and a father has more roles to play than a teacher; he too had certain things he had to make sure of. And that is fine.

The Black Pipe

Once my little brother and Kali were playing cricket, and I, angry with her for some reason and jealous that she was playing with my brother, began disturbing them, grabbing the ball and throwing it about, and at last I threw it off the roof. They went, angry, and complained to my father that I had been smoking. I ran and hid on the rooftop, but my father came up with a black water pipe and, without a single word, grabbed me by the hair and dragged me down and out into the street, and beat me in front of the whole busy bazaar, shouting, “Who taught you to smoke? Who did this?”

I cried at first, and then I stopped, because the pain grew so strong that after a while I stopped feeling anything at all. The beating itself was ordinary; what was unbearable was the betrayal, and the look on that girl’s face, the dawning realization that she had done a terrible thing. From that day I never looked at her again. She came to me many times, and I heard many stories, and I only smiled, and noted it, and moved on. I did love her, I did have feelings for her, and still I could not take her back. That day no one dared to stop my father either; he was pure fury. I think he grew tired, and I had gone numb. I have long since forgiven him. He was a man raising sons

between a revolution and a breaking home, carrying wounds no one had ever helped him heal, and he struck out the way frightened, overloaded people do. It was not right, and I would never raise a child that way, and still I hold no anger for him now, only a son's understanding of a father who was doing the best his own hard life had taught him.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Open World

One night I was sitting with my sister outside our house, chatting about nothing in the dark. It was wartime, and directly across from us stood the Nepal Bank, and out of nowhere a voice shouted from the bank roof, “Who is it?” loud and frightening. We knew the guard, an old man, and ignored him, so he shouted again, louder, “Who is there?” and then loaded his gun and cocked it and pointed it at us, and the sound of it was serious, his voice full of anger and doubt and fear and courage all at once. My sister and I were so shocked we could not speak or move; I could not even call out to tell him who we were, I was that frightened, and I thought we were one click away from death. At last my sister answered, and he shouted, “Get inside, who told you to sit on the road, do

you wish to die?” and we rushed in. Maybe he was a little drunk that day, joking or serious, we never knew; he used to come to our shop for tea.

My circle was widening into the open world. I fell in with the metal and punk crowd and spent whole days out of the house with friends from every part of town, drinking, gaming, bunking to go swimming, hanging around the ice-cream and street-food stalls, most of them run by people of Indian origin, and on festival days we would sleep out on the road. It was a wild time; I hardly know what I ate or where I slept most days.

The Guitar

I demanded a guitar from my parents. There were many players around me doing rock and metal, and I wanted to learn too, so I went to India with two friends, one a good guitarist, one a neighbour and classmate. It was my first time in India, though it was not far, only about fifty kilometres to the border. We crossed over, ate a meal, and went to a guitar shop my friend knew, where he tried several and settled on one, and we paid around three thousand five hundred Indian rupees for an electric guitar. I was so happy, and we came home.

Later I found that my own father knew how to play, so I learned the basic chords from him, and more from other friends. In time I understood that starting on an electric guitar had been a mistake; it never trained my ear properly, its sound was too small to play along with, it did not develop my fingers, and I could not feel the music the way I would on an acoustic. Still, that electric guitar stayed with me for a long time, played on many consoles and by many hands.

The Dam

My circle had grown to a great number of young men from all over town, friends from east and west and north and south, seniors two and three classes above me. Once about thirteen of us, with friends from other schools and local boys, bunked to go swimming at a big dam half an hour away. I could not swim, so I stayed careful, never going too far, never letting go of my grip, and a classmate of mine who also could not swim did the same, until somehow he lost his hold and the water began pulling him toward the centre, toward the dam gate. Everyone panicked. Those who could swim jumped in to save him, but in his fear he fought them, and it became impossible, and one by one they tired and gave up.

I sat on the ground, hopeless, imagining what his rich and powerful family would do to me. After a while there was no movement in the water at all; he was simply gone. Then some passers-by came running and asked what had happened, and we pointed to where we had last seen him, and one man reached under the water and pulled him straight out onto another channel, alive. We were flooded with relief; he even came up smiling. It was so stupid. The man who saved him said he was a communist commander. We stopped swimming and went somewhere safe to eat, and later, talking it over, everyone was quietly imagining jail, and then we began to joke, and we came home tired and relieved. And a few days later we heard that the same friend's cousin had drowned in that very place, and it blew our minds.

Selling the Land

Around this time my parents decided to bring the whole family to Damak, to sell all our land in Bhojpur and migrate. They convinced the grandparents too, but my grandmother was not happy; for a long time she resisted, unable to imagine leaving her place, her community, her friends, her empire, the memories built of her own blood and sweat. I was against it as well. I wanted that place to remain. I had even begun to travel alone from Damak to Bhojpur, and the first time I did the two-day journey by myself I felt proud and grown, and I used to wait all year for that festival and that travel. I loved that land; it held my roots, my birthplace, my memories.

But the others agreed, and my parents kept pushing the dream of an easy city life, and at last my grandmother said she would come only once the house was built. So my parents began building, and we sold all our land and houses and belongings in Bhojpur and settled for good in Damak, a joint family of nine living together again, with new farmland too. For a while we were doing well as a family.

The Red Pulsar

I learned to ride a bicycle from Kali and my brother, and soon after I learned a motorbike in a single sitting; my mother asked an uncle with a bike to teach me, they took me to open ground, and on the way back I rode us both home. It came easily and naturally to me. The landlord's sons had many bikes, and they did drugs and played music and slept late, and since

my mother had become their guardian while their father was in jail and their own mother had passed, they treated us like brothers, and I had the run of everything there, the drugs, the bikes, the instruments. Every morning I would wake early, take a bike of my choice, and roam the town like a cool boy, riding rough and fast and reckless.

One morning my brother and I took a red Pulsar to our building site at Kherkhera, and riding fast as always, I moved to overtake a tractor and crashed into a bike coming the other way. We did not fall, but it struck my right leg hard, the broken leg-guard cutting deep, and I still carry the bump. People rushed me to a nearby hospital, and all the while I was afraid, of what the big brothers would find out, of what had happened to the bike, of my parents learning of it. I sent my brother home to steal some money for the treatment and the repair, and he came back with a neighbour aunt and the money. They stitched me and sent me off. The other riders, who did not have a scratch, demanded money for their treatment and their bike, but I had taken all the damage, and I refused, and after a while they left on their own. It was my first accident; many crashes followed, but thankfully nothing worse.

Through the Window

nce an older friend asked me for some films and bought condoms, and I understood he meant to be with his lover that night. He sent me to sleep in another room, and later, drawn by curiosity, I crept close to the door and then to the open window, and there I saw two people together for the first time. My heart pounded so hard that I began to lose my hear-

ing under my own heartbeat; my hands shook, my mouth went dry, and still I watched, unable to look away. It was wild and overwhelming, a night I could not forget. Afterward I ran back to my room and could not sleep, checking again and again, wanting more of what I had seen. I wanted that closeness for myself.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Class Nine

Slowly I began carrying tablets and cigarettes to school, sharing them among friends, never selling; I did not care about money. Around this time Kali left for the UK, which was a sad thing, and I found other ways to cope, with friends and interests to keep my mind busy. My grades were slipping, though I was still doing all right, and I was good at sport, and into music, though I still could not perform before a crowd.

Around class seven a new policy came from the British government allowing all British Gurkha families to settle in England as citizens, and my friends began migrating one after another, so many good friends leaving Nepal. It was a sad, exciting time, full of gifts and photos and promises and good times before each goodbye, and I used to tell them that one day I

would join the British Army and follow. This was also when we discovered the internet, going to cyber cafes to chat on Hi5 and mig33 and Skype with the friends who had gone.

By class eight our class was already chaos, drugs and bad language, trading films, boys and girls in rival groups swapping crude jokes; we were reckoned one of the worst batches. I was often caught and sent to the office, and my mother was often called in over complaints, and she cried a lot; I gave her a hard time. My grades were dropping, so I joined a tuition class with a very skilled teacher who polished my mathematics and science especially, which is probably how I kept passing. And there was a girl, beautiful and popular in her way, from a British Gurkha family, of the many I grew up around. We had quarreled like rivals in class, and slowly that turned to love, with friends teasing us, and by the end of class eight we were lovers.

Then some local boys told me she had been the lover of a feared local boy, now gone to India and out of touch for over a year; she said he was her ex and she loved me now, as teenagers say. One day I got word that his brothers were looking for me at an old cafe near our school, their turf, and I decided to go alone, unafraid, with my own connections and my own pride and a lover to stand for. When I arrived, twenty or more boys stood ready to crush a single boy, and yet none dared touch me; I had my own vibe, my own aura. I stood smoking and waiting for their leader, the ex-boyfriend's younger brother, and when the talk came, they found no real reason to hit me. So they turned on one of their own, the boy who had carried the messages, dumping all their built-up tension on him.

And here is a bad habit of mine: from my karate training I have very fast reflexes, and I jumped in to stop the useless beating, and was pushed, and pushed back on instinct, and took a rain of punches and returned as many as I could, until in perhaps five seconds someone with more sense and more power broke it up and asked forgiveness. Many said sorry, and I understood it had all happened in frustration and reflex, and with a spirit of compromise we parted, the misunderstanding solved. Later they all became good friends of mine, and we played football and futsal together; I even met her ex, and he was fine with it. I had my lover.

CHAPTER TWENTY

A Product of My Environment

In class nine things grew worse, and I began stealing money from my family. By then our new house was finished, and after living in every corner of Damak we had come back near the very first place we ever rented, building our home just opposite it in Kherkhera, on the newly black-topped road they named New Amda Road. My mother moved our restaurant to a new spot as well, right in front of the IMO, the International Migration Organization, a US-based office that had come to re-

settle Bhutanese refugees in America, and she upgraded it to a foreigner's taste and standard, and business, especially hers, was good.

Once a Black man from the IMO came to eat, the first I had ever seen in person, very tall, and my mother called me to the counter and tried, in her broken English, to introduce me out of nowhere. I did not know what to say or do; it was so awkward, and he asked me random questions to help my mother's effort, but I was overwhelmed by his English and his accent and could barely answer, even after all my years of English school. I felt stupid, and I was unhappy with my mother for creating the situation. He paid and left, and I was left wondering how I could not speak with him, and what I had been learning all those years.

At home I stole from my parents' room, this time in the thousands, maybe thirty thousand rupees before they caught me, spending it to feed friends and buy perfumes and everything a teenage boy thinks he needs to impress a girl and his friends, going about in groups to restaurants and cafes. One day my mother caught me. I was walking with some friends and my lover when she called me aside and quietly asked whether I had been stealing from home, and I was stunned, and I could feel her pain and her disappointment, and she left without another word. I felt terrible, and I told my friends nothing. Late that night I came home to find my father waiting, and he beat me again, very hard, and I felt no sign of my mother anywhere. He told me not to come home until I brought back all the stolen money, and in anger I ran off swearing never to return. I went to the landlord's children and

asked to stay a few days, and they let me, and the next morning I met my brother at school and had him bring my clothes, and I began going to school from there. My lover and friends found out and were kind, bringing me food, but then my mother came looking for me, so I moved to another friend's house, and when that friend's father, an old friend of my father's, was told to send me back, I ran again to yet another friend's house. And so it went, until at last, somehow, I drifted home again.

By the end of class nine my visits to the office and the principal had multiplied. Once I spent an entire day being questioned, by teachers on the ground, in the office by another group, in the principal's room, signing paper after paper. I told them everything and never lied; I did not fear the truth, though I do not know how I learned that. I told them I was the master of the class's mess, that I distributed drugs but never sold them, where I got them, about my lovers and my family and all of it. And through their questions I realized something important about myself: that I was only a product of my environment, absorbing everything around me and reacting to it, not consciously filtering or controlling my own decisions. Those teachers were trying to understand and help me; they saw good in me and did not want to suspend me. I am grateful for that day, for it showed me how much the environment shapes a person. They saw my potential, in mathematics and science and computers and sport, saw the influence I had over friends and juniors and seniors, and saw me wasting all of it, and it saddened them as teachers. Then they called my mother and explained everything gently, and she understood, and

they let me finish my final exam. Whether the school sent me to Kathmandu to change my environment or it was my mother's decision, I left to continue my studies there, saying goodbye to lovers and friends and places and all.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Kathmandu, Class Ten

I went to Kathmandu for class ten, for the SLC, what they called the Iron Gate of Nepal. My mother and a village aunt came to find me a school, in Boudha, and I was already homesick and sad and confused. The first school they showed me was so small I said it was not bigger than our old school's toilet, and they laughed, and after seeing another and another I ended up at that same small one anyway, Wits Academy, because the principal promised my parents, with a hundred percent assurance, that I would pass with distinction. They had a hostel, and my mother left me there, and my life began to grow.

The school was small, but its chairman and founders were big, powerful men on the education boards, like dons of the city, and every student was some spoiled boy sent from another school, so it was a place of rebels and freaks and fighters and sharp, restless minds. The unity of teachers and students

and community was very strong; everyone knew everyone, and I soon felt at home. I made a good friend in the hostel, from Darjeeling, who stayed my friend the whole session. I was the first person any of them had met from the far eastern villages of Nepal, and they were curious about me; I wore rock and metal while they wore loose hip-hop, and I was physically strong, and I even began to draw crushes.

Meanwhile my lover back home, who had failed class nine and was repeating it, and I still spoke on the phone now and then, when phones were common but not yet everywhere, maybe one in twenty. There was a girl in our class, a niece of the principal, who had a crush on me and used to bring me chips and gifts, and some nights I even borrowed her phone to call my girlfriend in the hostel, though we spoke only now and then. As the academic year drew toward its end, everyone from class ten moved into the hostel, and things grew interesting. We were four who were always together, two boys and two girls, bunking and studying and going everywhere as one, and I began to like one of the girls, and she liked me, though we never could say it and stayed best friends; when my lover in Damak found out, they even fought once on the phone. I never lied to anyone; I was an honest boy who shared everything with those I trusted and cheated no one, for I understood that cheating is only lying, and I never lied.

Once everyone wanted to slip out at night for the Boudha Stupa festival, and I took the job on, stealing the keys to our flat and the main door and gate from the warden, and at night I opened them and led everyone out. We went several nights running, and on the last a friend threw himself into a local

boys' fight and ignited a massive brawl, so bad that one boy ended wrapped head to toe in bandages and went to the police the next morning, even naming names. Many in the community were questioned, but we hostel boys were never suspected, since no one imagined we went out at night; I threw no punch and took none, only watched it unfold, and I had never seen a fight like it in Damak. Another time some outside boys came and beat a student in our school's area, and without a word our class boys turned and attacked them back; those boys thought they could walk in as if they belonged, but our unity was strong and needed no reason, and an outsider's bullying was simply not accepted. And once the principal's niece was beaten by some local girls, and though no one knew the reason, a few of us guessed it: the girl in our group, my silent crush, was connected to those local girls, who knew me and teased me and smoked with me, and had learned that the niece liked me and was growing close to me, and did not like it, and worked to keep her away.

My academics were getting better and better; I was scoring above ninety in science and mathematics and the rest, though I was poor at English and Nepali, for I never liked grammar. We bunked more and more. Once, during Shivaratri, the whole class bunked school and hostel and went to Pashupatinath, and we were badly punished when we returned, but we had our fun anyway. It was here that I felt truly high for the first time. I had smoked many times before without much, but one day in the hills, looking down over a vast plot, a friend rolled

some weed and we smoked, and we laughed and laughed and laughed. I had never laughed so much or felt so good, and the view and the season and the mood were all just right.

On the Dashain vacation I went home to Damak and met my lover, and we went on many dates, drinking beer, sometimes getting drunk, meeting in friends' houses and restaurants. We tried to have sex and somehow never could; we kissed and touched, but I could not do more, even when we tried at our house. Maybe it was my mixed feelings, the old trauma, and the new crushes waiting back in Kathmandu. I know she wanted to, and I knew she was not a virgin, that she had been with her ex, and still I could not, out of shyness, out of fear. Once, coming home for a festival, someone broke into my things on the bus and stole my money, and I sensed at once who it was and caught him and began hitting him, an old man stepping in to help me. But the notes had already been broken into change and partly spent, and in my rage I threw the money down and demanded it back exactly as it had been, and the very man who had come to help pocketed half of it while pretending to gather it. I got back only half; I should have taken what I could and left, but anger had taken my mind, and I trusted the wrong man and lost the rest. Anger can do that to a mind, and I learned it there. I made many good friends here too, and since my house was far, on short vacations I would go to friends' places, to Hetauda, to one corner of the city or another, and in the holidays we would gather to swim and smoke and drink around the hills.

There was a farewell, or a welcome, at the start of the session, and we planned to play music on stage, and I practised song after song on the guitar and gained some popularity in the practice room, and I hoped it would be my chance to beat my stage fear at last. But when the day came we all got drunk somewhere and wasted, and could not perform, and I have regretted that missed opportunity ever since. Then the SLC came and went; I passed with seventy-six percent, above ninety in mathematics and science and computers, and under fifty in English and Nepali. And it was time to say goodbye again. Everyone began leaving the hostel one by one, and I lingered a few days, not wanting to go, sad to leave my friends and the girl I had silently loved. We finally confessed our love to each other, too late, ending before it had begun, both of us knowing we would never meet again, that I would go back to my lover at home and she would go on. It was a heartbreaking, sweet goodbye. That place gave me a different taste of life, hostel and open world in balance, wholly unlike Damak: Damak was free and broken and full of everything, of chemical drugs and random friends from every corner; here it was smoother and more refined, more rice beer and weed than chemicals, a concentrated circle of friends from school and community. I had time to heal here, and I think I became organized here. And soon I came back to Damak.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Army Dream, and the Rana House

Back in Damak I felt new; my style and personality and taste had all changed, and I was more organized and focused on my goal, which was the British Army. So I trained every day, running more than ten kilometres and playing football after, training hard and eating healthy. But that year my lover left for Kathmandu to study, planning to go on to England with her family, and it became a cruel dance: when I was in Kathmandu she was in Damak, when I returned to Damak she went to Kathmandu, and later, when I went to Kathmandu for college, she left for England altogether. In three years we barely had time together. I cried the day she flew from Nepal, sitting alone on my rooftop, having just said goodbye on the phone, listening by chance to Taylor Swift's *Love Story* on the radio.

Around 2009 I went to Dharan to train for the army, living in a hostel there. It was a different world again, two and a half hours from Damak, a cleaner city of the British Gurkha community, mostly Mongolian faces, more forward in fashion and luxury and party, with more of a Western touch. Life was calm: exercise in the morning, breakfast, rest, class at noon, food, rest, exercise in the evening, food, sleep. I was already fit,

scored well in the academics and was often rewarded in the weekly tests, and landed in the A-plus group for exercise; I could do eighteen and more pull-ups, a hundred and twenty and more sit-ups in under two minutes, ran my eight hundred metres in about two minutes and twenty seconds and my twenty-four hundred in around eight minutes fifty, and on selection day I placed among the top five in the whole Jhapa district. I even trained other students some days.

I trained there about six months, and when selection day came I passed everything, and yet somehow I did not make it. I was filtered out at the interview, where a Nepali man and a white man told me only to walk a straight line and return and asked where I was born. I think there was some weakness in my eyes. And so the dream of England was over for that year, the dream of reaching my lover there before she was gone. I came back in sadness and hopelessness, packed my bags and returned to Damak, though my coaches told me not to lose heart and to come again the next year.

Half the college session was already gone, and I could join no one in Damak, so, on someone's word to my mother that I could still enroll, I went back to Kathmandu, to another corner of the city this time. My friends had all started college, and no one would take a half-year student; I wanted to study computer science, which was part of why so many refused me, for they would take management or commerce or arts, but I was fixed on computer science. At last I joined Blue Bird in Kumari-pati, with a coffee cafe nearby, one of our favourite places, that kept guitars and a large smoking zone, where we spent most of our time among local friends and local gang members.

Once I went to a church here for the first time. My friend and I went in, and as the pastor spoke his words everyone, literally everyone, began to shake and cry, and we looked at each other, confused and frightened, having never seen such a thing. We tried to feel it and even to pretend to cry, and could not; we felt like we were evil, I do not know. It was mind-blowing, surrounded by shouting and weeping people, and slowly they calmed, while we hid our faces toward the floor, ashamed that we had felt nothing. When they passed around small white wafers and wine, we stretched out our hands too, but the pastor would not give us any, saying we were not ready, and we pulled back, more embarrassed still, and afterward we ran out and never returned, and made a joke of it. I had gone to a Christian school, and yet they never once preached to us or took us to church; we were free, and so I had never known such a thing existed.

Back in the hostel, studying science from mid-term, I made good friends, among them another addict whose father had died of an overdose and whose mother was in Australia. One day he tried to kill himself with rat poison. I tried to stop him, but he was too frustrated with life, unhappy with how his mother treated him, seeing him as just another addict, and he broke free and locked himself in the toilet and swallowed it. I was so angry, for he was dear to me, that I shouted, "Fine, if you have eaten it, I will stand here and watch you suffer, and you will beg me for your life, and then I will save you, for I will not let you die on my watch, but you have to beg for life." And I waited, and when he began to cramp and foam and cry that it hurt, calling for help, I slapped him and asked whether he

wanted to live now, and called the warden and an ambulance, and we took him to Ratna Hospital, where I stayed all night as they fed him charcoal and water and made him vomit. Before dawn he was already demanding to be discharged, and against all advice he forced his way out, and we walked back to the hostel joking and shoving each other. He loved me with all his heart and used to cry on my shoulder with his stories; I think he is in Australia now. We did crazy things together, beating up other students, in and out of the office, until once again I was suspended from the hostel, and I went to live with my aunt.

My aunt lived in a house the Ranas had built, once belonging to a royal family and passed down to some army colonel, a single vast structure of ancient hand-made Nepali brick, with gardens and fruit trees and vegetable fields, and five doors just to enter the inner house; it was a royal, fancy place over a huge area. This aunt was the second wife of my mother's eldest brother. Life there was good. She had a brother living with her, into computers and IT, who soon left for Australia, and she had her own connections among politicians and businessmen, who came in fancy sports cars and luxury cars to play cards and do I do not know what; they walked and talked and thought differently, living in another world. Once the police even took the two of us briefly before releasing us at once. We went to five-star hotels for dinner, to casinos, to fine Dohori dining houses with classical music; she moved in a world I was glad to glimpse. When she came to collect me from the hostel in a huge luxury car, it sent word among the students that I came from a big family, though I did not, and did not know it

either; she simply knew how to make an impression, and she was, as her friends said, the best of the best at cards. My lover in England still called now and then, and I had begun to forget her; she sent money sometimes, once even a touchscreen Android phone, when calling was very expensive. I sat my final exam from there, and afterward came back to Damak.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Overdose

Back in Damak I began to feel I would not go back, and I thought of studying here instead. I met old school friends who were studying science but planning to switch to economics, so I followed them into commerce at Siddhartha College, and started college again. Soon I was making new friends in the town, drifting back to toxic company. There was a shop near our house where I used to go to smoke, and I met local men there and smoked with them, and as the cool Kathmandu boy I was admired and made friends easily. We began drinking and smoking hard, and I gathered all my old friends, and we bunked our classes and went off on long tours, six to ten bikes of us, meeting at dawn to smoke weed, going home

to eat, gathering again to smoke and eat here and there, and riding late to the Indian border for chemical drugs. Before I knew it I had begun to lose my health and my looks.

When the time came to try for the army again, I went to fill out the forms and could not go through with it; I do not know if I simply gave up, but I could not leave my weed and my drugs, so I left Dharan and came back to my friends and my life, and I began lying to my girlfriend in England, asking her for money on invented reasons, to buy drugs.

Here I met another girl. I was not in love; she was not my type, or I do not know what I was thinking, but I wanted to explore sex, for until then I had done nothing but masturbate, still carrying that trauma from childhood, the Campus Mode incident with the older woman. While I was studying commerce in Damak, my science results came, and I had failed one paper, chemistry, so I went to Kathmandu for the retake. There I met this new girl, whom I had been talking to on the phone, living alone at the time, and we began to have sex, and I stayed with her a week or more. It was wild, and there was freedom, with nothing to do but be together, and I explored and expressed every desire I had, and she could take it and accept it, and it was a blast. Sometimes her friends came to stay and I would not leave her; I did not care, for the newness of it all was something to me, fresh and wild. I forgot the world for those weeks, and then the day came to leave for Damak, and I left.

In Damak I called my lover in England and told her about the new girl and what I had been doing, and she was shocked, and laughed, and hung up, and that was the last we ever spoke or looked for each other. The end had come. Soon after, I called

the new girl and broke up with her, and it was not easy for her; she cried and begged and kept calling, and I was heartless, an addict who wanted peace or did not know what he wanted, who had only used her to explore, without any love. I became stone to her; I could not feel her pain or her tears, maybe because I was drowning in my own, maybe because I was always on drugs. I feel bad, now, for how I treated her.

It was around the start of 2011, and we were using more and more. One holiday, in fine weather and good spirits, having just returned from a trip to Ilam where we had made new friends who cared well for us, one of those friends came to Damak, and we all decided to celebrate. We gathered in the morning and collected money, and a few went to the border for heroin and chemicals, and we waited all day smoking weed and drifting about, and when they returned in the evening we went to a friend's house where there were no parents, and used together the whole night. We were all overexcited that day, I do not know why. We sat in a circle, many of us, and one friend served everyone, dosing himself between the turns, and I do not even remember falling asleep.

When we woke, a friend and I tried to wake the others, and one would not wake. We pumped his chest and threw water on his head, and still he would not, and we rushed him to a nearby hospital, still thinking he breathed, and they told us it was too late. Only then did we understand that he had kept far more for himself, the last one still using while the others slept one by one, taking tablets and injections too, hitting between the turns as he served us. Our senior told us to report ourselves, so we went to the police, who held us a week, an in-

terrogation that never moved forward while they tried to send us to jail, life there rough, fifty people in one small room with a single toilet, sleeping on the floor. After a week the dead friend's mother came and asked the police to forgive us and lift all charges.

While I was in that cell, my parents did not come, and they sent word that I was better off in jail, and it broke me. We were five friends inside, and every family came with food but mine. My friends' families supported me and helped me out, and it was that grieving mother who took all five of us out, saying, "I have lost one son to addiction; I do not want to lose five more. It was not their mistake; it was my son who died." I felt the whole weight of her understanding. Riding home on the back of a friend's scooter, tears rolling down in silence, I felt for the first time what freedom means, and how the law works, and what life is. I felt for my parents too, for all they had dreamed for me and all they had struggled and sacrificed and fought for. I wanted to change. Our family was going bankrupt, and my mother was crying day and night.

But I was still an addict, and I kept going back, trying to fight it. I fought with friends while drinking and using heroin, shouting at some never to call me again, "I have to study, get lost," and then they were my friends again and we loved to smoke and do our stupid things together. For a time I even invested in selling heroin, with a partner from the village and two boys who smuggled it up to us, and we made money, and our one rule was that we never used what we sold, only weed and drink, never the heroin and syringes we dealt, and we kept our word, and we dropped the smugglers when we began

drawing too much attention. Life went on. The final exam came, and again I failed one paper, accounts, having attended maybe a quarter of my classes, bunking the rest, and so I decided to quit school; I no longer saw the point of studying irrelevant things inside those boxes while something deeper was wrong in my life. I got drunk, I stole, I even crept into other houses at night to steal phones. My parents sold the restaurant, and we had no income; my father tried online gold trading with a new circle of friends and lost far more than he made, and once took me to the Indian border to look at some scam, a machine that could hold ten thousand or more SIM cards, whatever it was, and we came home and dropped the idea. Everything was coming apart.

PART FIVE

The Search

A first book on a train, a grandfather's peaceful death, a wish-list of everything worth knowing, and a night in a meditation hall where the crying finally turned to light.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Delhi, and the Alchemist

Near the end of 2011 a friend from my circle introduced a business venture, and he made it sound so interesting, even promising a way out of drugs and into money, that a group of us decided to go. I asked my mother for a little money, just for the train, and three of us set off with some others from Dharan. It was a wild experience. I had bought a book to read on the train, *The Alchemist*, the first book I ever read like that, and it was another moment of my waking up. The train itself was fascinating, three nights of crowds and people coming and going, hands reaching in to beg, food carried from home and bought at the stations, and us smoking in the toilets now and then. It was fun, a break, the start of something new.

We reached Delhi at night, and I could feel the smell of it, all chemical and dirt. There were no stars; even at night the sky glowed from the lights and the haze, and the water smelled of chemicals, and the streets were narrow. They kept us in an apartment where all the Nepalis came to learn the business, a small fee to stay a week through the training. Each morning we woke, ate, dressed in our best, and rode nearly an hour and two metros to the office, so packed that we sometimes sat on

the floor, so tired we fell asleep on the way back, and all the while I was fascinated by the big buildings and the metros and the super-cars and the crowds.

The business turned out to be a multinational network scheme, selling essential oils and fancy burner lamps, our real goal being to bring in more people. But what caught me was the psychology of the training. It opened me up. I spoke before the crowd, and I cried, remembering my past, my parents, their pain and sacrifice and dreams, and everything I had become, how I was hurting everyone around me and had been so irresponsible. It all came pouring out over many sessions as others shared stories I could feel in my own life, and I called my parents and told them my feelings, and they broke me and gave me hope at once, a way to change and live better and work for myself and for them. I was sold. I was ready to be a businessman. They taught us to calculate life in short, mid, and long-term plans, to sell a product, to build a personality, to sell any idea, to dress well, and the week ended, and we went home to Damak.

We stopped hanging around our old friends and began preaching the scheme, following their scripts, the questions to make people curious so we could take them to Delhi to train. Looking back, we were in some way brainwashed to brainwash others, though that is how all trade works, promoting a thing until people believe and buy. The catch was that on the second visit you had to carry money to invest, maybe twenty thousand rupees. We gathered new friends and went again, this time with richer friends in the clean, comfortable AC class, curious what difference money made, and I read another

book on the way. And so it went, coming and going, bringing new people each time. But I made no money, my parents never fully believed in what I was doing, and before I could prove it worked, the company closed, called a scam, and the government tightened the border to those going that way. So life drifted by, no school, no college, no job, only weed and thought. The heroin circle fell away, and I was left with village friends and booze and weed, watching more conspiracy videos, learning from the internet, reflecting more and more.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

The Wise Old Man

Around this time my grandfather passed away. He was a man of quiet example. I never once remember him sleeping beside my grandmother; as I heard, in his youth she found he had affairs and children in another Bhojpur village, and she punished him by making him sleep alone the rest of his life, and never spoke to him again, and he never looked at her straight. He accepted his punishment and stayed, doing his duty, never asking for more, never quarreling, never shouting, without greed or fear. He was just a man. He would walk to the farm, work all day, and come home. Simple.

The first full meal I ever cooked I made for him, on the farm; before that I had never made more than tea and eggs, and I was so proud to manage a whole meal of rice, dal, curry, and pickles, and he ate it blissfully. He was endlessly kind, to animals and plants and people and birds and even spirits, and I used to follow his every word and mantra and movement in the pujas. And the way he died was in peace, asleep in his bed with a smile, no disease, no sickness, just a calm last breath; he was blessed. That day it was as if he and my grandmother both knew. She came close and held his hands and spoke kindly to him, tears rolling as she whispered in his ear; she loved him, and he loved her in their own way, and they were saying goodbye, and just like that he left. I went back to my room and did not come out; I attended no ceremony, went to no burning place. He had gone, and I had my own ways. The wise old man had left, and their home would never be the same. My grandmother ran the house, but he was its backbone, keeping the peace and holding the family together, someone to look up to and learn from, a provider, a giver, a protector, a guide. A man.

The days passed the same again. I began to grow my hair, to wash with natural things, aloe and neem, and to explore conspiracies and alternative ways, reading books and following them. My parents had begun teaching yoga and meditation at home, in our big hall, and though I had not yet started to practise myself, reading about it was slowly changing my perspective; my father even bought machines for simple therapy, and many people came in the mornings and made noise, and I hated having to wake early for it.

I heard of GED from one of my brother's friends and joined it, studying from home, and it was another turning point. The curriculum was nothing like Nepali school, world history and mathematics and English reading and literature, taught in a different way, and much of it matched the alternative histories I had been chasing, which amazed me and drew me deeper into hidden histories. I studied it with total curiosity, learning from the side-conspiracies too. I meant to join a bachelor's after it, but the year I passed, the government removed GED from its list of equivalents to grade twelve, and I could no longer enroll, so I let it go, leaning further into learning my own way, through documentaries and history and literature. GED taught me how to research and read what I wanted on my own; it changed my whole idea of college and school and education, and I felt free and easy about my future, no longer afraid of being uneducated.

Somewhere here I began to design my own education, the things I actually wanted to learn: my own body, mind, and soul; food and farming and the practical skill to build things, furniture and houses and machines; psychology, society, children, religion, gods, history. I wanted to travel; I wanted to be free and did not know how; I wanted to understand how I function as a human. I was frustrated with the world and could not understand myself; I wanted something and could not act on it; discipline and routine and self-improvement were so hard, and I could not control myself. I wanted to understand why I was not in control, what was controlling my mind and my choices, how I was connected to the world and the cosmos and nature. I wanted the real history of the earth

and mankind, my place and role and responsibilities in it, the truth about money, who prints it and controls it and how. I wanted to know why there are borders and why we cannot move freely across the earth, why my country was called poor and third-world despite all its nature and beauty, why our ancient knowledge was neglected while we read everything in English, why there are no food trees everywhere for anyone to eat, why none of this was taught at school, why we build no machines to solve real problems in the home. I wanted to know everything. I did not yet know it, but this wish-list was the first shape of what would one day become Hunate.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

The Mountains of Tamke

We had sold everything on my father's side in Bhojpur, but my mother's people were still there, grandparents and an uncle and aunt and cousins, so my brother and I went to visit. We celebrated the festival together, and my uncle took us to a new place called Tamke, his wife's home, a full day's walk high on the mountain, around three thousand metres, one of the most amazing landscapes I had ever seen, green grass hills like Switzerland. The next morning we woke sore and aching from the walk, in the cold, and the grandparents

there came with fresh, still-warm honey, giving each of us a whole bowl, maybe three hundred millilitres, when we had only ever eaten it a spoon or two at a time. Frightened, we drank it all, and soon grew dizzy and slept without knowing why, and woke in the evening full of energy, all the pain gone as if by magic. It was the taste of real nature, of the pure freshness of that place.

The next day they took us hunting, many village boys gathering with three rifles, excited to show us the wonders of nature, cleaning and loading the guns while I watched, respecting their word not to take pictures. We hiked up into the dense, beautiful jungle, fresh air and grassy hills stretching as far as the eye could see, the best place I had ever been. They divided into groups, some hidden, some driving the animals, and I was on the chasing team, making noise across one hill; I heard shots and saw the blood of an animal, but we caught nothing, and as dark fell we turned back, and on the way I begged to fire a shot at a tree, and my uncle refused, and somehow I fired it anyway, and the shock of it was wonderful; I wanted more, but they said the night would carry the sound to the police, so we stopped and came down. I had thought myself strong and fast and flexible, and beside those men I was nothing. They were wild, fearless, built by nature for nature, able to take a buffalo's neck in a single swing of the khukuri. They are the children of the Nepali mountains, what those mountains produce, and they remain an inspiration to me.

The Lodge

Around then my mother started a business at home, a small hotel and lodge she named something like Hotel Village, and customers gathered quickly, for she already had them. We ran rooms too, and business was good, especially the rooftop drinking in the evenings, and by day and night couples came for a room. There I saw a great deal, prostitutes and well-off men and women in secret affairs, and it made me a man full of doubt about how unfaithful the world could be, how addicted to lust. I saw women left naked and drunk, people cheating, quarrels before and after, beautiful innocent women taken hard and loud, plain women holding rich and powerful men in their hands.

Once a man I knew brought two girls, and I was serving them when my eyes met one girl's, an Indian girl, thin and pretty, and I smiled and went out to sit with friends on the roof. After a while the man said she wanted me, that she had refused him. I hesitated, for I had a girlfriend, but I was drunk and he kept on, and I gave in and went in, and the other two came out. She lay drunk and smiling, and I turned off the light and did what I did, straight to it, without a kiss or an embrace, without feeling, and went back out to my friends. I think lust and fear are mixed: I had the fear of disease and the lust for her smile. It was my first time with a prostitute. Another time, fishing with village friends, catching fish and eels and crabs by electricity, we caught a snake, and I decided to cook and eat it, having seen others do so; I cut off the head, drained the blood, skinned it easily, diced and fried it, and it tasted exactly like chicken, all bone and little meat. We ate field mice and rab-

bits and birds too, and once I caught more than ten pigeons and ate them; we would go into a hunting mood with the villagers of Kherkhera. It was all experience.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Awakening

Around this time I began a deeper practice. I would wake near three in the morning and walk to a nearby temple, sit by the pond and meditate for hours, and come home around six to continue at home. A friend joined me sometimes, also deep in conspiracy, and we would meditate and practise yoga and then go hunting for wifi to download videos, since we had none at home; we were hard-core about it.

That friend almost lost his mind to it. He began acting strange, and one day came to me saying, “Brother, I have transcended; I see people’s inner faces now, I see red beings living inside everyone, and they are crying, shouting at me to help them,” and he began to play with broken glass in his bare hands. I listened carefully and quietly, trying to understand, trusting him and doubting him and half-jealous all at once, and he looked strange to me. I asked what he had done differently, and he said he had done everything I taught him, and also stared at the sun for a long time while bathing at dawn,

and breathed fast and deep beforehand. Soon his mother came weeping for help, asking what had happened to her son. A priest said the ancient souls were trying to enter him, and he was sent to his mountain birthplace for ancestral rituals and offerings, and came back normal, and carried on with his life. I stopped teaching him anything more. It was strange, and a good experience.

For my part I felt nothing so extreme, only my body and mind and soul growing clearer, myself getting deeper into myself, trying to understand the world and our bonds, to arrange everything I was learning and connect the dots, to change the course of my thoughts and actions, to find a way to live better and help my family. And I realized later that it does not happen overnight. I still had a long time to learn, and a long, large time yet to fail. I still needed, it seems, to become more miserable.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

The Girl from Up Kherkhera

Back in Damak, going around smoking weed and sharing my internet findings with a village circle, there came a week-long temple festival near our house, at the Dhaneshwor temple, a Shiva shrine that had stood since before my birth,

once just a peepal tree and a place to worship, now growing into a bigger site. Every day there was a celebration, and one evening, in the crowd, I saw a girl dancing and singing, and I fell for her on the spot. I kept watching her across the crowd, and our eyes met, and I smiled and waved, and she ignored me, so I told my friends I liked that girl, and they began watching too. When she glanced at me again, I clutched my heart and pretended to fall, as if for her, like a scene from a movie, and she smiled, shy, and stopped dancing and sat down like a shy little girl. I knew she and I could be one, so I sent a messenger to bring me her number at any cost. The messenger came with it, and I was overjoyed, watching from afar as she hid her face and ran off with her family. Later I learned she came from a powerful, wealthy family from Upper Kherkhera, bordering our Lower Kherkhera, her uncles a police inspector, a business tycoon, a man with weight among the Damak gangs. Friends warned me not to play with her, but I would not listen; I like a challenge.

Around this time our step-brother came to live with us, the son of the Tamang woman who had left when I was about three. His arm was broken and he had come for treatment; I guessed his maternal family no longer wanted him, or had sent him to claim property we had already given him, a portion of land with the villagers as witness and papers to prove it, or perhaps he only wanted his father's love. It was not easy to accept him arriving uninvited like that; truly, no one liked it. But my mother was generous and treated him and sent him to school, and he stayed. He was a little annoying, hungry for attention, wanting to be a politician, and in time he took up run-

ning and gained some fame in national games, doing well. Still, his aura was not liked; he walked as though everyone on earth knew him, and I did not accept him, remembering how he had rejected us with harsh messages when we were the ones reaching out, forcing his way into our family now like a leech. I even beat him a few times for crossing lines, for getting drunk and disrespecting me or my friends.

Then one day a speeding car of drunk boys, sons of a wealthy politician, hit him from the wrong side of the road, a critical accident, and he was taken to the BNC hospital in Birtamod; the car was caught, and they promised to heal him and pay every bill. And despite not liking him, I was the one who nursed him, over two weeks in the hospital, day and night, until he died on my watch, his Tamang mother beside him weeping while I could say and do nothing, only watch him go. I went to the funeral, one of thousands of people. He had fought so hard to be positive, persistent and dedicated, never giving up on his dreams though he was not accepted, hiding his hunger and his tears, trying to share a love he had never been given. He was never shy or tired, endlessly confident, able to walk up and speak to anyone, boy or girl, police or don or child; he was king of his own world. And just like that, he was gone.

You Don't Know Us

Maybe the same day, or a few days after, we were celebrating again at that temple, and on the way home a few boys were shouting slurs and making a scene. It was my village, so I told them to stop, and one pulled me aside, wrapped an arm around my shoulder, and said, “You don’t know who

we are; keep quiet and run home if you want to get home well.” I was shocked; strangers in my own place, threatening me. I could not let it stand, but they kept shouting, so I ran home without a word, and my friends, sensing something, ran after me though I had not called them, asking what had happened, and I said the boys had threatened me. In my mind I had run to ambush them from another side. I took a khukuri from my house, and my friends grabbed bamboo and whatever they could find, and we ran to wait on their way home, and cornered them. When I saw them still coming and shouting, I ran at them, drew the khukuri, and struck from behind, and my friends charged, and they were shocked, dropping to folded hands, “Brother, I am not the one, forgive me.” I held them one by one and asked, “Who is the one who asked if I knew them back there? Who is it?” and they were scared to death, all of them, and I let them go with a warning: “Now you remember me. My name is Khem Raj Pradhan. If you make noise around here again, remember me.” That day they had a taste of us and our place. The police came, for my mother and the village women had also complained of the boys’ noise and language, and I heard the police beat them and sent them home. The next day the elders of both villages met over it, and it fell in my favour.

When I tried the number the messenger had brought me, it was wrong; I had been tricked, and I was sad. But a few evenings later a call came, not from that girl but from a friend of hers, and the flirting began, many girls testing me, and I suppose I passed. It turned out she was from the very village of the boys we had fought, and the elders who had come were her

cousins, and she was even the sister of my brother's classmate; so many connections we had not known. After all this, we began to date. I would cross the fields to meet her behind her house at night, kissing and touching there, meeting maybe once a week, talking for hours on the phone. I was the bad boy, and she the sweet princess of a wealthy family. I wanted to have sex, and she would not, afraid, and we quarreled over it many times, until one day it happened.

That day her house was empty, and she called me at night. I was excited and ready, with chocolates and condoms, showered, the town quiet, and around nine or ten she called, and I crossed the dark fields to her back door. She warned me her grandparents still slept on the ground floor, so we crept up quietly to the first floor, and it was thrilling and dangerous; had her family found out, I am sure they would have sent me to jail on some false charge, or set gangs on me. I even scouted the roof, as I always did, to know where I could hide or jump and run. And in that big, fancy room, after more than six months of meeting and teasing, she was ready, and it was our first time, in the dark she insisted on. We stayed lovers a long time. My family knew, and hers, and her brother, and the whole village, but few dared speak of it openly; perhaps her uncles did not know, or pretended not to. We never went on dates, never to a restaurant or hotel; we met only at night, hidden from light and people, at her place or mine, mostly twice a month. Once we spent a whole day at Namaste Jharna in Dhankuta, bathing under a waterfall. The longest we ever had

was a night, at her place or, on Laxmi Puja, at mine, the one day she could come out to play Bhailo with friends and stay the night.

One night at her house, her uncle came home late, and my soul left my body. There was nowhere to hide, and he was already at the first-floor gate, so I squeezed into a corner of the bed and stayed, drenched in sweat, my heart pounding, mosquitoes everywhere. He stood outside asking her to serve his food, just standing, watching the road, and then he called his three dogs, a pug, a Dalmatian, and a local mastiff, and began to play, and I thought I was finished; I was already calculating the speed and the risk of running. The dogs bounded onto the bed and began sniffing at me, and the uncle came in saying, "Why are you climbing on the bed? Get down, get down," coming closer, until my girl called out, "Uncle, your food is served, please come," and the whole pack and the uncle went off, and he even pulled the door shut behind him. I breathed the longest breath. I came out slowly, wiped my sweat, dressed, ready to flee, and could not. She came in, as scared as I was, and told me to wait until he had gone to his room, so I hid again in the corner until he slept, and she came back after her chores, and I spent the night, and left before four in the morning. I cannot imagine what would have happened had we been caught; we would never have been married. Once she even came to my place in New Baneshwor, wanting only to drink wine and stay the one night, and I cooked and we drank and were wild together, and I think we made the neighbours jealous; she was free and drunk and unlike herself.

As the years passed, we could not marry or run away, and saw no future. She was studying nursing and wanted Dubai, and I was turning radical, wanting to live off-grid, and I was addicted, toxic, possessive, arrogant, stubborn; I could not make her trust me or give her security or comfort. I was just a man chasing sex. And she decided to marry another. We had loved each other and fought terribly, broken up and patched up, broken many phones, and I even slapped her in public once; we had lived like a story. We had our last night on Laxmi Puja, when she was already with the man who would be her husband. Around November 2016, I knew it was the end; my mother had come to take me to Kathmandu to work with her, and I went, and we broke up on the phone, and I stood crying on the street until my brother felt my pain and came out and hugged me and calmed me. Then I went to Vipassana for the first time.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

Zeitgeist

Back in 2012, while I had left school, my brother was still studying, and after college he and some friends went to Kathmandu and rented a place in Nakhipot in Lalitpur, where I used to go and spend my time, watching anime and smoking

while they were at college. One day a friend brought two documentaries, *Zeitgeist* and *The Venus Project*, the talk of his college circle, and being free and already deep in this kind of thing, I watched them. They spoke of religion, money, history, and new ways to live, and I was blown away. I began to talk about it constantly, and the others watched too, and we all went a little crazy over it; and since I was free while they were busy, I went deeper, into more documentaries on food and chemicals and the education system.

This was where I began to build my own strong perspective on life, to recall and re-evaluate my purpose, to dream of new ways to live far from the modern social system. That room became a place of endless debate, friends coming every day, students of social work and civil engineering and business and music and cinematography and computing and media, arguing for hours about conspiracy and religion and philosophy. It sharpened my ability to critique and analyse and compare, to plan, to find problems and solutions, and above all to listen. I was living in Kathmandu, and sometimes in Damak.

At some point my mother told me to start working and found me a place, a five-star resort, Hotel Park Village in Budhanilkantha, huge, far to the north while we lived in the south; she knew the manager from Damak, where he had cooked at the IMO while we had our restaurant. I started at the dishwasher, an easy job with electric washers, then moved to preparing vegetables, peeling potatoes and onions and garlic and ginger, and then to waiting tables. I did not enjoy it, the gossip and the complaints, though the place itself was beautiful. Once a group of Nepali guests called me over by the pool, and the

man complained about a small crack in a bowl, and I had to apologize and throw the whole dish in the bin, and I thought how I had never once looked at my own plate while eating; I saw so much fresh food wasted there, while we staff were not even allowed to eat it. Once, at a politicians' seminar, I served a school friend I had once beaten in public for mocking me, now there representing his father, the same friend whose house I had sheltered in when I ran from home. We shared cigarettes and sat in his room, but it cut me inside to see where he stood and where I stood, serving a boy I had once dominated before the whole school. I could not imagine living that life, and after six months I quit.

Then I applied to go abroad and passed the interview for Saudi Arabia, two of us from Damak, with visa and everything ready, and at the last moment my heart refused; I could not leave Nepal, or my lover, or perhaps my weed and my peace, so I rejected it and stayed. I went back to Damak, and there I finally got a tattoo, since I no longer needed to keep my skin clean for the British Army; that time had passed. It was a simple crossed khukuri on my left chest, and I was excited, though at some point it hurt so badly, and I was high on weed, that every prick stung sharply and I felt dizzy and sick, and had to rest before we finished. I was very proud of it. Back home I would talk for hours about the conspiracies and everything I was learning on the internet, friends listening in curiosity, smoking and getting high, and it was as if the weed drove their imaginations into a hidden world, and they loved it.

CHAPTER THIRTY

The Family Breaks

Then my grandmother passed away, and hers was a sad ending. She had fallen in the bathroom and broken her hip, and walked slowly in her last days, lonely, missing her husband, missing her home in Bhojpur, crying and begging my father to send her back to her community. She hated the city, with nothing to do but eat and sleep, tired and angry most of the time. I was with her, teasing her always, playing drums and guitar with her, carrying her, calling her “old woman,” and she would laugh and swat me with her stick and call me a rascal; even when she was angry I would tease her until she laughed. Then one day she simply passed, and like my grandfather’s funeral, I did not attend; I stayed in my room and did not come out. The one who had held me when I came into this world was gone. She was a furious woman; people said she had built all our wealth, married an orphan boy and raised a fortune and a family to standing in the village, made people respect and fear her, given to many, and there she was, crying and suffering at the end. After her, the family broke completely; my parents could no longer hold it together.

Around 2014, on the verge of bankruptcy, a man came promising to save us, to get a larger loan from another bank and split the money, paying our loans with our share and doing business with his. With no other option, both my parents

agreed. He did the paperwork, took the money from the bank, and vanished, paying none of the interest he had promised, leaving us owing sixty lakh rupees, and my parents, frantic, hunted him and filed a police case. Somehow he came to Damak to face us and the police, a cunning, sweet talker who charmed everyone and walked away, and my mother decided to go with him to do business together and keep a close watch.

So my mother left with him to Kathmandu, and they ran a huge rice factory, packing and unpacking; I once saw them swapping the rice sacks and raising prices, a scam, or so it looked, though maybe I was wrong. They asked me to stay, but I could not. It was there that my brother and I used to practise our English and make our romantic promises, to get better in life with knowledge and skills, to build a beautiful farm life, he learning about plants and I about something else, to reunite our family one day and live together again. I think it shaped us; in time he did become a geologist and I a permaculturist, and we have built projects together since, and will keep building. We are a destined team. It was there, too, that my brother told me we had once had a baby sister who died young, and I broke down and cried, and told him he was lying, and he told me to ask our mother, and I did, and she grew angry and said it was not true and that we should not joke about such things. I was furious with him for making me cry, and emotional, I do not know why. And I came back to Damak, spending my time between the two cities as life went on.

My father was turning toward sadhana, becoming a Newar priest in Damak, and at a great puja at home I performed the fire ritual, the jagya, praying into the fire again and again,

hundreds of times, for one thing only: knowledge and wisdom in life. I wanted nothing else, and that prayer left a strong mark on my perspective and my choices ever after. Meanwhile a rumour spread in Damak that my mother had left my father. I knew the truth, that she had gone to recover our money and home and property, but no one explained it, and my father did not see it that way; he accused her of cheating and stealing everything, and we children were left confused, and I felt somehow it was my fault. Perhaps I did not understand what family meant, having been away so long, and I was irresponsible and did not care. The bank loans had bankrupted us, the family had broken and scattered, and I was more lost than ever, unable to help, doing drugs and failing at everything, a total loser and spoiled child who had lost his health, down twelve kilos from his training days, wanting change desperately and not knowing how, doing yoga and reading and watching documentaries and still unable to see a way out.

We left the old room and shifted to Alok Nagar around 2014, where a group of my brother's friends invited us to stay; my brother and I were only taking shelter, not paying, for we had no money, having a hard time with the separation and the bankruptcy, and those friends were generous and never made us feel like outsiders. One empty festival night, when everyone had gone to Damak, a friend and I went to Thamel to celebrate, and drinking there we met a German man and invited him to our place, and he simply agreed, and we set off on the two-hour walk. On the way I asked whether he was afraid to follow strangers into the night to a place he did not know, and he answered, "Is there anything to be afraid of?" We said, "No, but

still,” and he said he had been doing this his whole life, that he travelled for it, that life is to move forward and keep doing the unexpected. That casual confidence, the way he explored and saw life, was exactly what I needed; he unlocked a hidden courage in me, and I began to dream of travelling like him. We climbed the gate and shared what food we had, some soup and bread I cooked, and smoked weed while I grew paranoid, and my friend played him some songs, and in the morning we took him to the bus station and photographed him, and he left with the most precious gift, that question.

I worked a month at an airline ticket agency, a friend’s aunt’s company, booking flights, walking forty-five minutes each way with music in my ears, which was the part I loved; it was easy, a substitute post for a staff member on vacation, and I received my first pay there, not much but something. My mother’s father passed away. We moved to New Baneshwor around 2015, where my brother took a place near Alok Nagar with his girlfriend, two bedrooms and a shared kitchen and bath, cozy and small, though sometimes ten people lived there.

There I took a job at a new US call centre near our flat, a night job selling websites, hoping to improve my English, and I do not remember selling a single one; I would come home in the morning, eat, and sleep all day. I disliked it because the owner only sat and complained that we sold nothing, without teaching us, and one day, angry and unpaid, I started a quarrel and shouted, “I quit, give me my money, I am leaving right now,” and they understood and promised to pay in the morning, and when I revolted several staff walked out with me,

maybe five of us; I heard the company later shut down. At a second call centre the boss was chill, and interviewed me in the working hall in front of everyone, and we liked each other; it was a lead-collecting company, not a website seller, and I brought the practices from before, the meetings at the start and end of the day, and someone suggested a presentation competition and he took it up, and he listened to everyone, and I improved and became the top lead collector, winning many of those competitions, researching US places and weather and news so we could speak as if we were there. It was a fun place. I brought two friends to join me, and two girls there became my constant companions, always beside me, asking me to teach them to speak and sell as I did. Once I even proposed to them all that we be together, a thing among us, and they came, and we made coffee and breakfast in our room, and when the moment came we all grew nervous, with no real plan, and dropped it, and everyone went home disappointed, and we slept.

Once, returning from work on a packed bus, so tight there was no room to move, a girl stood pressed in front of me, short, fresh-smelling, and in that closeness something passed between us without a word, a rhythm we both caught and shied from and caught again the whole ride, her breath and mine rising together, until my stop came and she got off at the same place, and we both walked away pretending nothing had happened. After a few steps I thought, no, this cannot be the end, and ran back and called to her, and she was beautiful and hot, and I said she had made my journey, and she pretended to be shocked, smiling and shy, and said she did not know what I

was talking about, and I felt bad and apologized and left. But I still felt incomplete, and went looking for her again, and found her having tea with a crowd of friends, and could not speak, only waved, and she waved back, and I left, unable to express myself before so many girls, though I could see in their eyes they were talking of it. It was a crazy thing, and I thought of her for a long time, and looked for her on the bus for days, and never saw her again. She was gone, just like that.

At a third call centre, where the three of us went next, the vibe was full of jealousy and unhealthy competition and masks, and one day, sitting before the computer trying again to sell a website, I felt a strange heat and dizziness rise in me, and I struck the desk and the keyboard and stood, and everyone stopped to watch, and the manager came, and I said, “I can’t do this, I quit,” and he understood and sent me to rest with cold water, and I went home the next morning and never returned. That day I made up my mind never to work for money again. I was done with it, the working all the time and waiting for a salary already spent on a list longer than the pay, a debt-loop with no end. I had heard that to truly learn a skill and keep evolving, the motivation must not be money, and I felt it there; I had stopped exploring and training myself, growing comfortable and waiting for a wage, and I hated it. I wanted to work for myself, to make my own path, ready for all the criticism and sacrifice that would come, and I decided not even to listen to my parents about earning money.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

The Earthquake

One day I sat with my uncle in a restaurant at the New Baneshwor crossing, hungry, waiting for our food, and as it came everything began to shake. People screamed and ran; buses knocked into one another, bikes fell, people fell. I sat confused, wondering whether to take the food, whether to pay or simply go, then came out slowly and calmly, watching. In the distant hills houses were collapsing and dust rose into the sky in many places, and big buildings swayed like snakes. It felt like a movie, like the end of the world, all the crying and shouting and the buildings falling, and I watched it with a curious mind, for in a crisis my mind grows quiet and everything slows and I see clearly, something I must have built through years of extreme situations, and, I confess, I was in some way loving it, the chemical of it rushing through my cells.

The phones were dead, no signal, so we went straight to my brother and his friends in Alok Nagar to be sure they were safe, and found them joking and gathering their things to move to open ground. We took our valuables and a football and a guitar to the nearby school field, and stayed there for days as the aftershocks kept coming. All of Kathmandu was living in the street; many returned to their villages, but we stayed under an iron shelter, hundreds of us together, roaming

by day, playing football and guitar, killing time, and always hearing of deaths and fallen houses. I felt sad for all the lost, and I felt very small. I had seen such things in the news and papers, but to feel it in the body was another thing entirely, and it opened my eyes. This city design is not good, I thought; these houses, these developments, this greed to live in the city and chase money, are not good. With all our science and technology we had built useless cities where not a single house could be trusted, and everyone slept in the street. How stupid. We were nothing before nature, and I felt that if we want to be called smart, we must follow nature's laws and patterns. It took a long time to heal, and life went on slowly.

The Property

We had been played by the banks and the men around them, visiting the courts again and again, and I came to know how banks and law work in Nepal, a game of power and money and knowledge and influence. The bank auctioned our property to the public; we were going bankrupt, and vultures circled to buy our land cheap, some pretending to save us. We had property worth around a crore and a half against a sixty-lakh loan, all because of the man who had promised to pay the interest and clear the debt and then run. One man from the bank promised to buy it for a crore, and made my mother and me sign the papers, and paid only five lakh, then blocked our calls and vanished, having already cleared the loan and made the property legally his, even sending word for us to leave the house, the papers showing we had received all the promised money. It lit another fire in the family, and it was

part of why my mother had left to chase the first man in the first place. But my father would not give up; knowing something of the law, or knowing someone who did, he flipped the coin, and after years in court he retrieved every property we had lost, while the man who tricked us vanished for good, still on the run to this day. For years the thought of that man burned in me, and it poisoned no one but myself; in time I learned to set it down, and I hold no hatred for him now, for a man who lives by cheating carries a heavier sentence than any I could wish on him, and our family was saved anyway. That is how our family was saved, though my mother never came home; she stayed with her business partner and continued her venture. When that business too went broke, all they had left was a bike, which they mortgaged for forty thousand rupees to start a lumber trade in Dhading, carrying wood to Pokhara, and in no time they were doing well, with jeeps and trucks.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

Vipassana

Somewhere in this time I broke up with the girl from Damak, and I went to Vipassana. It was something I had long heard of, and finally I was there. They interviewed me, asking again and again whether I was sure, warning that it

would be hard, and I was ready. A bus took us far north of Kathmandu into the hills and the jungle, and I loved the place the moment we arrived. The first day was only briefing, the rules and the regulations, and the journey began the next: waking early, meditation, breakfast, rest, meditation, lunch, rest, meditation, rest, dinner, rest, meditation. No speaking, no interacting with anyone, quiet and simple. I loved it, and yet inside I was exploding, all the pain and suffering and greed and trauma and fear coming out as anger. Some days I could not focus, and grew angrier, and the strange thing is that I connected everything to the man who had taken our money, my mother's partner, and my anger toward him grew and grew.

I began to imagine him as the source of all my family's suffering, and I wanted to kill him, and I started, in my mind, to plan it, and every time I could not meditate I grew angrier still. One night I was so agitated, and a man near me was snoring, that I went and woke him to say, "Stop snoring," all my emotion coming out as agitation. On the third or fourth day I spent a whole session imagining killing that man, full of frustration.

Then a break came, an evening after food, and I stood staring at the sunset. It was November, and the air was turning cold, and as I looked at the sun a wind blew across my face, and tears rolled down, and I smiled, and the wind blew through me as though I no longer had a body, passing straight through me, and I felt erased from the physical world, and the tears came harder. I tried to hold them, for volunteers had noticed and were coming toward me, and I did not want that, and I rushed to a tap to wash my face, and the bell rang, and every-

one filed in. I lingered and went behind them all, and passing through a shaded stretch of plants, something pierced my whole body again; I felt nothing, as if my body had dissolved into nothing, and I could not hold my crying any more. It was not a cry of pain and sorrow, or maybe it was that too, but it felt more like dissolving into nature, like nature asking me to cry in her lap, pushing me, and I let her in, and I became her and she became me. In that moment I changed. Something inside me changed. It touched my soul. I touched nature's string. I flew with her, I became her, and I felt light and free and full.

That night I no longer meditated to kill that man. I let go of blame and complaint. I forgave myself, and I forgave everyone. I saw that everything simply is what it is, not good or bad, only reality, only what I am, nothing to hide from. I accepted myself and my past and everything as it was, and I detached the events from the emotions, and began to reshape my life and my way of seeing. And that was it. After that, everything grew easier; I slept well while the man beside me still snored. I understood, too, that some of what my father had taught me as a boy, the things I never wanted, were part of this very technique, and I felt grateful to my parents. I understood the power of the food elements and our connection to the body and how to feel them. I organized my thoughts and my learnings and my conspiracies, and I could feel every cell inside me, and I came out in what I can only call a fuller version of myself. Then I went back to my brother's place and prepared to leave for my mother's in Dhading.

PART SIX

The Idea Is Born

Life on the road and in the ashram, a stranger's house across a dark river, a school in the hills, love from every corner of the world, and the day a locked-down valley became the first ground of The Joon Project.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

On the Road

I was clean now, of drugs and cigarettes and every toxic thing, and I promised myself to stay that way, and I began helping my mother with her business, and she welcomed me. It was a good place to be, near a river and a brick factory, where we cut and sold trees with many labourers working. I loved working on the trucks because it let me travel, so the journey began as truck labour in my own mother's company, and I was writing a journal again. I went to Pokhara for the first time, and to Lumbini, Butwal, Nuwakot, and many places besides, loading wood, stones, cement, bricks. Pokhara was amazing; we arrived before dawn and waited on the truck, and when the sun rose I stepped out and saw Machhapuchhre shining, and I felt wonderful, in that fresh and chilly beauty. In Lumbini, when the truck had to wait all day to load, I hitchhiked to the birthplace of the Buddha, everyone giving me a ride, and roamed the whole day.

I loved life on the road, though the first driver was a bitter old man who barely spoke, and when he did he spat curses at the world; frustrated, or perhaps unhappy that the owner's son rode with him day and night so that he could not skim oil

and run his side-hustles, and I later learned that skimming was the only way drivers earned more, and every one of them did it. When our truck broke down near a river in the hills on the way to Nuwakot, I spent three days waiting, with only a water tap and a tiny food shack nearby, and I enjoyed even that, eating at the shack, bathing there, sleeping in the truck writing my journal, helping them fix a fan, once even crossing the river with them to see a wedding. People were confused that a labourer read and wrote so much, and I never told them I was the owner's son; I liked being nobody, and that way I saw the road plainly, the corruption and the prostitution, the psychology of those who live their whole lives moving, the effect of dust and noise and endless waking hours.

Once, with a young driver, going to Pokhara at night, two girls with a small boy flagged us down, and he stopped and told them to climb in. I thought they wanted a lift, but he knew what it was, and began to flirt, and one of them flirted back, while I and the other girl stayed quiet. He drove into the dark and stopped again and asked me, "Which one do you want?" and I was shocked; they were road pleasers, and I said I wanted none, and stepped out and waited while they finished, and refused again when it was offered, for I had control of myself now and a different view. On the way back we passed the same place, and this time the driver only sped up, and when I asked why, he said, "Didn't you see?" This time boys were waiting; the girls would seduce the drivers, learn the situation, and rob them the next time around. I was amazed and frightened both. On the road, too, the traffic police took money at every stop; pay, or they would make you wait and find a reason to fine you

or threaten to unload and reload the whole truck, costing you only your precious time, which on the road is money, and they know it. Our driver always paid, though I hated it; passenger buses were spared because of the public witnesses. Once a clever young driver even punctured our own tyre to take it to his own garage, skimming our petrol and a cut for the repair; such things were common. And the constant travel and noise and heat and pollution wore on my emotions and my health; I grew irritated and impatient, and when a driver younger than me smoked heavily, I slowly began again, and relapsed after months without.

After a time I had a great fight with my mother's partner, one of the rudest men I have ever known, who treated everyone like a slave and spoke in harsh words and slurs, and abused even my mother. I feel more pity than anger for him now; such hardness is almost always armour grown over an old wound, and I have learned not to hate the wounded, only to keep my distance from the wound. I kept the peace until it was too much, and then I decided to quit and live on my own. I told my mother to leave that place, and she could not see how, so I said I was going. I went to Kathmandu to say goodbye to my brother, and left with a backpack and a little clothing, saying I would not return any time soon.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

Haridwar

And so the real journey began. I took a lift on a truck to see my mother one last time to say goodbye, and she gave me five thousand rupees, and I went on. I wanted to learn about human health, and the only place I knew was Patanjali Yogpeeth in India, so I bused and hitchhiked my way to Haridwar. I was frightened here; it was a new place, and I had never left home this way, and I was not going back, with no friends and little money, and I had made up my mind never to call anyone for help even if I needed it.

I reached Haridwar in the evening, and when I asked the way to Patanjali they said it was twenty kilometres off, and I was confused, tired, wanting only to eat and sleep. It was a beautiful place, heavy with religion everywhere, sometimes a little too much. A man told me of a job at a soap factory, and I took his contact, and I kept looking for a cheap, almost free place among the many ashrams, until I settled on a fifty-rupee room, good enough, with a shower. Later I heard Nepali being spoken and met a group of kind old men, workers on their way home, who took me to dinner, and I slept well, wondering how I would survive this world, with whom I would share, how I would find money and food and a place to sleep, where my family and friends were, feeling the deep pain of loss and, somewhere, the excitement of the journey.

The next morning I woke before the sun and set off walking to my destination. It was a fresh morning, many people bathing in the Ganga, others running and walking for exercise, and I thought how conscious these people were of their health, and I liked that feeling, a cold breeze passing, a slight smile on my face, loving the whole walk. When the sun came up I began asking for a lift, and a roofless tractor carrying corn took me, and I could not speak over the noise, but I remember the bliss of it, the speed and the cold wind on my face, flying. Then our paths diverged, and a bike took me the rest of the way, a rude-voiced man who helped me anyway, and left me before that huge, huge place.

I did not know where to go, but I knew what I wanted: to meet Ramdev and Acharya Balkrishna and tell them I wished to learn about the human body, through yoga and meditation, and about nature, through Ayurveda. I asked everyone, dragging my heavy bag, tired, until someone pointed me toward Ramdev's cottage, where two armed guards asked where I had come from and what I wanted, and told me to wait, and then, learning I had not eaten, sent me to check into a room with food and a bath. There I met many travellers, some for treatment, some visiting, some studying, and when I told them I meant to meet Ramdev they said it was impossible, that one could not just meet him, but I did not care; I would meet him anyway. I caught Balkrishna outside as he left his office, and past the guards he let me approach, and I told him I wanted to learn yoga and Ayurveda, and he told me to write a letter and a proposal, and left, and I was at least relieved. So I wrote two letters, for Ramdev and for Balkrishna, realizing it would be

hard to explain on the go to men so busy and so guarded; why would they spend time on a random man from nowhere? But I was persistent.

The next morning there was a college function, and Ramdev came to congratulate the students, and I decided to sneak in, disguised as a student, greeting others as friends, and somehow it worked and I was inside the private session, face to face with him, everyone bowing for blessings. I did the same and thought to tell my story, but he was constantly distracted, and I saw it would not happen, so I tried to hand him my letter, and his guard took it. I waited outside again, and when his car came I gave it again, and this time he took it, and I even slowed his car, and I felt he had noticed me, and I felt good. Now I had only to wait. I joined the morning yoga, ate there for free, read in the library by day, joined the evening yoga, ate, and slept. After some days the apartment in-charge began asking how long I would stay and explaining the fee beyond three days, and I went again to Balkrishna, who said they were very busy and told me to carry on and stay until further notice, and had his guard arrange a private room for me.

And it was there, in my notebook, that I wrote the whole idea of The Joon Project for the first time. I had never done it before, and as I wrote it grew clearer, and I grew more confident, and when I finished I gave a copy to Balkrishna too. I made friends there, and shared my stories, and one Acharya who had studied under Ramdev long ago shared much wisdom with me about learning; I met another Nepali boy working as a guard. People called me crazy, saying they had worked there for years and never dreamed of meeting Ramdev or

Balkrishna, and I told them it was because they had no reason to; I did. After about fourteen days I decided to leave, tired of waiting, wanting another place; as the Acharya had said, the basics alone would take eight years, and I did not have that time. I even wrote my brother a letter, unsent, asking him to come and take me home in the eighth year if I had not returned, for I feared I would change and stay there all my life and forget why I had come. One thing shook me: I could not open the Venus Project website, or any of its content, anywhere in India. That project was my inspiration, and my dream was to join it with Patanjali, the modern science and vision of the West married to the ancient natural law of the East, two forces that together could rewrite the fate of the earth; I wrote letters to both of them, and it was what I had been trying to say to Ramdev all along. I did what I could, and then I left, hitchhiking back toward Nepal, staying a night in Butwal at the house of a man I had met in Haridwar, meeting an old college friend, a civil engineer, whom I invited to a future meeting in Kathmandu, and then I set off on foot again, by shortcuts, toward a school I wanted to volunteer at, Maya Universe Academy in Damauli.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

The Long Walk

It took me three days to reach the school, and each night was its own story. The first day I walked a paved but empty road, rarely a vehicle, none stopping, perhaps because the way was already hard and they wanted no extra load. Villagers watched me strangely, and one warned it was not safe to walk so late, but I kept going, and the sun went down with no hotel or lodge in sight. I thought to sleep in a temple or a school or a park, but rain clouds and lightning gathered, and I had to find shelter. Some children told me of a lodge in the next village and led me there, and by full dark I reached it, relieved, a cozy small place crowded with road workers who watched me with suspicion, as if I were unwelcome. The owner said he had no room, having stopped renting long ago, and they asked who I was and where I was going, and demanded my ID, and I answered politely and truthfully, and asked for food, and they said only soup was left, and I took it, uncomfortable under their suspicion.

All this while a thin, bent man watched in silence from the window, and when at last he spoke, it was in English, and I answered, amazed, and the men inside told me to ignore him,

that he was a lunatic. He spoke again in Hindi, and I found him interesting, and wondered why they called this man mad, for he seemed fine to me. Then, out of nowhere, he said, "Come with me, I will give you a place to sleep and eat at my house," and that was all I wanted to hear. Everyone warned me not to go, even following to the door, saying they would share a room themselves, and I was uncertain, but I decided to go with him. I bought two cigarettes and lit one and walked into the darkness by the small light of my black-and-white phone, lightning in the sky, otherwise dark. He barely spoke, only answering what I asked, walking with his hands behind his back, and I grew scared, wondering if I had chosen well, until I remembered the German man in Kathmandu and his words, and I felt there was nothing to fear; he is a man, I am a man, and I know what to do if things go as I fear. We walked a long time, and it began to feel like we were heading toward the river, stones and sand, and I grew more afraid, and asked where his home was and why we were at the river, and he said it was a temple of the goddess Kali, and his home lay across the water; I wondered if I was being led to a sacrifice, the vibe was so intense, until I saw the reflection of a roof in the thunder-light and felt better.

At his home I stretched my tired body, and he brought me water, and called me in to meet his family. An old woman was cooking potato soup and roti over coals, and his sick father lay flat on a bed. They must once have been well-off, I felt, brought low now by a son the world called mad. His father did not speak, but I sat with the mother while she cooked, a kind and humble woman, and she gave me kafal, a hill berry I had

never tasted, and I was so happy to have it. Later the man took me to a room and shared his stories, and his strange questions: why the letter “W” is shaped as it is, why the letters of every language take their particular forms, things I had never thought about. He had joined many radios into one working set, and told me he had studied IT in India once. I saw in him a genius trapped by family and an unsupportive community in the middle of nowhere, the wasted potential of Nepal, and I wondered what he might have been near a city. I slept like a log, and in the morning said goodbye, and though he begged me to stay, I left.

I hiked on, taking a shortcut through the jungle over the next hill, and there I found the very berry tree we had eaten from the night before, and, overjoyed, I climbed it and ate my fill for breakfast, thanking the old woman and nature for feeding me out of nowhere, though in my excitement I forgot my water bottle there, and thought it a fair exchange. That evening I reached a temple with another berry tree, this time kimbu, sweet and good, and I ate a great deal. At night I reached a big town of bus stops and shops, and tried to find my way, with no map, only a list of place names on paper, and when no one knew them I used a cyber cafe and found there were two places of the same name, and had to call my friend to be sure which. It was late, and I did not want a hotel, so I went to the police station, where three men at the gate, confused, checked my ID and let me stay and gave me food, and I slept on a bench in the waiting room, mosquitoes and all, at least safe. The next morning, after fifteen minutes of walking, I had to relieve myself, and it came a great deal, dark red from all the

berries. At noon a hospital jeep carried me far, near my destination, crossing the Dudh Koshi, its water white as milk, past old temples like ancient castles across the river, a beautiful place, and I reached Damauli and walked the last long stretch to the school.

From this journey I understood that it is truly easy to travel if you want to: find work and keep moving, changing it now and then. The people of the road are people too, with their own web of connections across the whole country; everyone is always moving, and if you want to go a certain way, you only have to ask, and a hundred travellers will refuse you, but if you are persistent one will help, and that moment feels so wonderful and blessed that you forget every rejection. Life is like that too; you must keep doing what you want, not knowing when things will align with your direction and carry you there in an instant, and you should not be afraid to express what you hold inside. It showed me, too, how every part of society is connected and yet functions alone, and that this is exactly why our social system is so disconnected, its technology and ethics and environment and development all severed from one another.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

Maya Universe

I had heard of Maya Universe long before from my brother's friend, and wanted to come, but when I first applied they asked five dollars a day, so I dropped it; now I came with a different approach, to meet the founder directly and ask to help. The people welcomed me warmly and made me feel at home so fast, many foreigners among them, the children welcoming too, and a man took me to meet the founder, who was cooking his dinner, and being an understanding man, he let me stay. I taught yoga, and science to the younger classes, helped with cooking and construction, everywhere and anywhere. It was a wholly new world, travellers coming and going from all over the world, bright and curious students, an English-speaking, open-minded place where we worked hard by day and drank and smoked at night.

The children were learning so much here, computers and music and languages and cultures, meeting thousands of volunteers and travellers, in a culture of openness and constant change. I began to dance with them, and to open up, performing for the first time before students and teachers and volunteers, singing and playing guitar, doing football and karate

and everything; I had found how to express myself, and this place loved every multi-skilled part of me. I gave my best here, and it helped me understand more of myself and of the community and society I wanted to build; I felt I had found a place to live, for I had, after all, been travelling to find such a place, such a community, and my vision was growing clearer. I even called my little brother to see it, and he came for some days and we explored the villages and hills, and he liked it, and I was happy; I called my mother too, but she could not make it.

Solving Conflict

There was an American girl with whom I had some friction and feeling and teasing; she said she studied psychology back home. One night she, I, and a mutual friend lay on the roof watching the stars, feeling it, waiting for that friend to leave, and when he did not, I left them to it and went to sleep. The next morning the founder called that boy and me and asked what had happened, and I was shocked to hear that she had complained the boy tried to kiss her without consent. I thought, if it had been me it would not have been so, for she and I had already shared our feelings, though that friend did not know it. The founder told me to resolve it at once, so I gathered them, and two other girls, and I spoke, of books and love and travel and freedom, of Nepali culture around flirting, of forgiveness and mistakes and healing and friendship, trying to show that a thing between a boy and a girl need not be taken to founders and society, that we could understand it as friends and solve it among ourselves and forgive and not repeat it. It took more than two hours, for those girls were hard

to convince, and in the end the boy apologized and everyone was at peace, and I felt proud; that friend thanks me still, and the founder was amazed, and I discovered that I love such moments of pressure, and that resolving conflict is a strength of mine.

Presenting the Idea

Around 2016 I went to Kathmandu again to present The Joon Project, inviting from our own circle social workers, geologists, civil and computer and mechanical engineers, filmmakers, journalists, and business students; a friend reserved a college hall, and we presented for three or four hours while another friend filmed. The idea was simple: an international community of researchers and social redesigners, spreading awareness and living with purpose, all of us living and working together as friends and family, designing houses and farms and social structures and media, and if we could not yet, we would train ourselves into it. Everyone liked it, and yet something was missing, and we could not continue, and everyone scattered. I went back to the school, saying we would meet again and meanwhile keep learning on our own, for I knew that if we did not start now we would all be lost to the rat race once college ended and we left that shared flat; the system is built that way, and that is exactly what happened, everyone finishing college and going their separate ways after money and career, until it became only a good talk. I realized too that I was not ready, that I still had much to learn, and I decided to keep learning and travelling on my own. I even went to volunteer at a Vipassana centre in Pokhara, a small

place in the hills among the lakes, but they sent me out on the ninth day for talking too much and disturbing the meditators, and for trying to convince one student not to give up, and for complaining that their food did not follow the course; I had my problems with those organizers, and they with me, and I went back to the school.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

Cambodia

Teaching yoga again, a Chinese girl took an intense interest, asking many questions, following every instruction; when I said raw food was good, there she was eating raw pumpkin and gourd, which amused the children. She followed me everywhere, and once, as I practised guitar for a morning performance, she joined me, and after a while began to cry, looking at me, and would not say why, only staring, and I felt it was love. I asked if she wanted a hug, and she did not answer, so I hugged her, and asked if she wanted a kiss, and she only looked deep into my eyes, so I kissed her, and then she confessed her feelings, that she felt peace around me, and just like that we became lovers.

One weekend, at a barbecue with twenty-five and more volunteers, local and international, playing games and singing and sharing stories, the talk turned to shame, and someone challenged whether anyone could stand naked. I was saying there is nothing to hide or be ashamed of, that we all have what most people on earth have, that privacy is an illusion, and when someone challenged me directly I said I could, and a girl said she could too if I would, and I stood and took off my clothes, and she followed, and we stood there saying there is nothing to be ashamed of, while everyone clapped and shouted. I truly believe this is the truth of our age: there is no such thing as privacy any more; we think we have secrets, but the internet holds it all, and only a few, with money, buy and sell it to businesses and companies. My Chinese lover and I went to many places together, and when her time ended early she left, and I left the school too; she would come back to Nepal on her vacations, and we hiked around Pokhara and camped on the hilltops each time, and once we went to Cambodia to volunteer on an organic farm.

Going to Cambodia was very hard. She got the tickets and visa, and on the day I went to the airport with everything, they would not let me fly, demanding an itinerary, hotel proof, a financial statement, and I argued and explained and they refused, telling me to bring documents next time. I went home and told her, and she insisted and bought another ticket, and this time I came prepared, with a thousand dollars in cash and the visa and ticket, and still they rejected me again and again, saying I would not return, that I was running away to stay illegally, a stupid thought I had never had, and I was furious and

hurt; it was my first time trying to fly abroad, and I never knew how strict, how corrupt it was, and I came home and read of many such complaints, now a victim of one myself. She bought yet another ticket, and this time, on my friends' advice, I had her send an invitation letter from the organic farm stating where I would stay and who would care for me and for how long, and with everything in hand I went again, and after many questions they finally let me pass, my first international flight, alone, to Cambodia.

She met me at the airport, and we hugged and kissed after so long, in a wholly new place, and rode to the farm; I had brought gifts, hemp bags and a purse. Cambodia felt like Nepal, but cleaner and a little better, perhaps for having been colonized. More than anything I was happy to be there, on that organic farm doing so much without any animals, its huts of wood and mud, its special food, its wonderful volunteer house with a huge library on sustainability, and my lover and I sleeping in a small A-frame hut, with an amazing dry toilet; it was my first taste of a truly organic place, and I felt inspired and blessed. There were more than twenty people, mostly French, the owner from France and his wife Cambodian, with two sons, one in the city and one home-schooled there, sharp and intelligent and speaking many languages. They were making manure and a mud house, and I joined at once, playing guitar and singing in my free time, and after a few weeks we went south to an island. And I saw the ocean for the first time, on a boat into the middle of nowhere, water everywhere, overwhelming, and I fell silent, needing time to absorb it, for I was

from the Himalayas, from land, from the northern winter, and here everything was reversed, and my whole being took time to adjust.

On the island we kayaked and swam and ate seafood and drank and made love, but it was a Western island of Western people with little to do, and I was getting lost, changing inside and out, and my silence unsettled her, and we decided to part as friends, and she left while I stayed on to explore alone, invited by locals to drink and sing karaoke, given free rides around the sea. I volunteered a week or two at a restaurant and then went to the capital, renting a bike to explore the slums and lotus farms and salt fields, meeting my second prostitute there, who gave me a blow job though we did not have sex, going to a massage parlour, to Angkor Wat, to the night city, all alone by bike. One night I heard there would be plankton on the beach, and not knowing what that meant, I went with goggles after work into the ocean, and it was a dream world, stars in the sky and a million stars in the water, and though I was scared, unable to swim well, the waves pulling and the night stealing my sense of direction, I loved it, the plankton shining on my skinny arms and legs, and I marvelled at what nature can be and how many wonders it holds. Another day, fasting in a forest by the beach, hungry, reading, I watched local children gathering a strange fruit, and after they left I plucked one, and it was so sweet, with something hard hanging beneath like a cashew, which I kept and did not eat, and later learned the raw cashew is poisonous, and was glad I had waited. Before Cambodia, a fortune teller in Kathmandu had told me that Lord Indra slept dormant on my forehead and

that I would soon reach his greatest temple and awaken him, and I had thought nothing of it, for I rarely went to temples; and yet there I was, wandering ticketless inside Angkor Wat, past the checkpoints as if a local, and when the police finally caught me and I said I was looking for a ticket, they laughed, amazed I was already inside, and let me go without the five-hundred-dollar fine. I did not even know it was a temple of Indra until I came home to Nepal, and I was amazed that the prophecy had come true, though I still do not know how she knew, or what it means.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

The Eastern Hills

My brother's friend was principal at the eastern branch of Maya Universe in Gaighat, and invited me, so I went, hiking days from Damak through Bhojpur and Khotang, by bus and tractor and on foot. When I arrived I fell in love with the place at once: a school on a hilltop with a panorama all around, mountain ranges stretching east to west, always chilly, the village visible below, a welcoming black dog named Bhalu, goats and ducks and chickens, the classrooms scattered across the compound, the volunteer house on the peak, the office and kitchen below. It felt like a place I could live in, and I did. It was

smaller than the central school but with more land, more connected to the community, with few international volunteers and few students, like a family. A volunteer there knew permaculture and tended the farm, and I helped him build a greenhouse, and taught where I could, and later a German came as an English teacher and a French girl as a science teacher, and things grew more interesting; we drank heavily at night and worked hard by day, and life was as simple as that: work, eat, drink, sleep.

I began making out with a Swedish girl, shy and introverted, into books; we did not speak much, having little to say, but we kissed when drunk. Once nine of us camped by the river, an American girl, the Swedish girl, a Nepali couple, a French permaculture man, the principal, an army man, one of the school's founders, our dog Bhalu, and me, gathering cooking tools and firewood from the village, cooking chicken and rice, drinking, dancing, with books and music and a tent. When the American girl fell from a rock and cut her leg badly, the army man tended her and the party went on, and then we found the Swedish girl had cocaine and opium, so we had it all, cocaine and opium and local and branded liquor and weed, and it was my first time with cocaine, and we went wild, we boys stripping and dancing around the fire, forgetting the food, which was full of sand. In the morning the friends who had stayed fresh told us the whole story, how we had passed out one by one and been looked after; I woke with sand in my mouth and ears and all over my body, everyone the same, and we washed in the river and, in no condition to hike back up, took a bus and walked to school, throwing up, unable to eat. A crazy, wild

night to remember. We went to Biratnagar together afterward, and to Damak, and went clubbing, and somehow the Swedish girl and I ended up together, and tried to make love and could not, forcing something that was not there, drunk-attracted and silent when sober, and she made an excuse of no condom and we stopped, and that was the end of it.

I spent a festival alone at the school, having nowhere to go, neither to my father nor my mother, and had a good time; there was a Nepali girl, my brother's ex, and a girl who said she was the daughter of a high priest in Vatican City, cute and shy, and I played guitar and sang while she spoke of being a professional violinist and wished for a violin, and with no children to teach we wandered the village and celebrated with local families and went to the melas, and when they left for another school I stayed on alone, having the time of my life, reflecting. A French volunteer became a lover; returning from a far place, we all met and drank in Gaighat, and I tried to kiss her and she refused, and we slept in separate rooms, but days later, drinking again, we kissed, and then began having sex, always when drunk; she said she had a boyfriend but wanted to live in the moment, and we did, and when she left after some months I felt sick for three days. So it went, volunteers coming for three months and leaving. We hunted in the jungle too, porcupines and big lizards, and ate them.

At some point my father called about a great event at Patanjali in Haridwar, and I went with a Damak group by booked bus, stopping at a place that fed travellers free, which I had never known existed and later heard were all over India. We stayed in better rooms than before, with AC, for a huge yoga

certification event, and I attended and got certified, and at the end they invited people to become sanyasis, an eight-year path with an interview by Ramdev, and I put my name down, one in perhaps two thousand daring it, which frightened the Nepalis who had come with me. On the last day they performed the fire ritual and recited the count of such pujas done, some twenty million years, they said, kept alive by secret, selected priests through floods and ice ages and mass extinctions, and I was amazed, for here in the modern world we speak of five thousand years of history and this priest spoke of twenty million; the mantras shook every cell in me, thousands chanting as one, and it felt godly, and I boiled with courage and strength. Those of us going for sanyasi were given a small book of Sanskrit to memorize without understanding, for a test, and then taken to meet Ramdev in person, the moment I had waited for. Inside sat a German photographer, a sanyasi who had left a life in Australia, and Ramdev. I sat and asked if he remembered me, and he said no, and finding Hindi hard I asked if he understood English, and he did, so I reminded him who I was and that I had given him letters, and he only nodded, and I said plainly: when I needed you, you did not care; I followed you and begged you and wrote to you, and you did not care, and now you act as though you care; that is no way to be a guru. He said little, told his assistant to look after me, and I left, satisfied, for the German photographer had liked what I said, smiling and noting it as I went, and I had already quit; I was not ready for eight years, and had only wanted to speak my mind, and came home to Damak and the school.

Around then our friends from Kathmandu and Damak came, most of them from the Joon presentation, and thirteen volunteers from Imperial College in England, a yearly thing under some contract, more than thirty of us at once, and we had a blast, working and drinking and living our time. I almost hooked up with one English girl, but as we sat alone one night she farted, drunk, and apologized for ruining the romantic moment and kept farting, revealing she had not been to the toilet in a week, and it killed the vibe, and we laughed it off. There was no proper water place at the school, just a pipe lying about, so I designed and built a proper tap, my first, leading the whole project to a fine finish. When the English left after two weeks, it was only the Nepal friends again, at our regular ways.

The American Girl

Then came an American girl, not new, back this time for thesis research rather than to volunteer, pretty with her glasses and thin frame and big smile, speaking good Nepali. She taught in the government schools downhill and researched the village, and spent her free time at our office and kitchen, living just below the school in a student's house we would go to for a drink. One morning, joking in the office, she told of her frightening bus ride and a man who had watched her, and I made a bad joke about rape at the wrong time, and she slapped me, angry, and left the room, and I felt terrible. She came back and apologized for reacting impulsively, and I apologized too, and she said she wanted to talk about it after school, and later we walked up the hill and shared our per-

spectives, and I told her that because I have lived through such things, I take them lightly, as experiences and lessons rather than as things to cry over, which is perhaps why I did not hesitate to say it. She took time to absorb my story, and we came to understand each other, and became friends. We began joking again; she ran every morning while I woke early to make the fire and wash dishes and make coffee, and she would return from her run and always drink from my cup, staring into my eyes. One day, as I teased that people had trouble not falling in love with me from my eyes, that she should be careful, she came close smiling and asked, “Is that really true?” and kissed me. She was shy and said sorry, and I said we would talk later, and thought of it all day. That evening we agreed to try, though I was not fully ready, and from then she would come early into my bed and tease me, direct and aggressive, when my friends were in the same room, and it took me time to adjust, but in time we made love, and I helped her with her research, translating the villagers’ records, and in explaining our own culture, our belief systems and how they preserved nature and forest and water, I came to understand its value, and loved passing on what the old people told her. A German girl came as a volunteer too, who became a good friend of mine, a lesbian. Soon a festival came, and we all travelled together, hiking to Khotang and Bhojpur, and four of us went on to Makalu Base Camp while the others went to Damak and the American girl to Kathmandu.

Makalu, and the LSD

At Makalu I saw real snow and the near mountains for the first time, and every moment was awesome. I swam in a frozen lake and blacked out from the shock of the cold, unable to move inside it, and yet when I came out I stopped feeling cold at all, dressing and feeling more alive and strong than ever, all the tiredness of the walk gone. On the way back we took LSD, walking through a snowfall in a closed valley, everything slow, and walking alone I saw with sharp clarity, the branches on far hills, and on one mountainside the patterns of an ancient war, soldiers and chariots and horses and weapons as from the Mahabharata, and I stayed watching a long time, feeling I was recalling my past. It was one of the good chemical drugs I have done, full of positivity, though I was damaged; and I marvelled that a single chemical could so alter the human mind, and shape the history of our evolution, and I wondered how much of nature stays hidden from us. I ran naked everywhere out of excitement, on snow and river and lake and mountain, wanting to feel that cold, and I loved it. When I came to Damak after the trek, my lover came too, and we celebrated with my family, and then returned to the school.

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

Principal

Life went on, and some politics began at the school. Our principal decided to leave and hand the responsibility to me, and everyone agreed but one founder from the village, who began protesting, coming to the school threatening to close it, drinking early in the morning, behaving badly. Then the other founders came, and we held a parents' meeting, and I was given the school to run, and a new journey began. It was not easy, but I pulled it off; some parents doubted me at first, and I won their trust by working, and the protesting founder was sent out. I made changes: policies to give books and uniforms for free, and I refused the distance between principal and student, taking everyone as friends. I taught yoga and extra activities, the body and its challenges and sport, and I walked and played and ate and joked with them, becoming one of them while keeping the balance; I did not set them tasks so much as tell them to interact more with their parents and help at home with the daily work. The difficult students I kept beside me, carrying my books, keeping them in whatever class I was in, giving them their assignments, so as to watch them constantly and inspire them through action and story

and real practicality, until they became like little principals themselves, helping the others with kindness and, when needed, authority. I saw them not as problems but as children with more energy than most, who, if harnessed, would make the best leaders and influencers, and I was right; I changed a few of them this way, giving them roles to channel their energy, and it worked.

One holiday my American lover and I went to Pokhara and hiked to a base camp, on her last day in Nepal, her time over, and we had our time and parted, saying, "This chapter is done now," not knowing when we would meet again, a sweet ending, and I came back to the school. I drew more Germans to the school, and that German friend, the lesbian, helped me greatly; we collected more money and gave free books and uniforms and excursions to Kathmandu, scholarships, and many facilities, doing great as a team; once we took the children to Kathmandu for an excursion and picked up a new German volunteer there and came back together. Then the Chinese girl came to visit, bringing gifts for the central school, staying a few days, wanting us to love each other again, and I was not sure, still in contact with my American lover and now feeling for a new German girl, and I was confused, though everyone remained good, open friends. She left, and I felt bad for her; I was drawn to many girls and hardly knew who was who, and if I could I would accept everyone, for everyone wants love, and I was ready to share it, as long as no one grew possessive or jealous. I meant to be free of bondage, to give

love without letting anyone possess me and without possessing anyone; but soon I too would be corrupted in this game, and change.

The German girl was young and full of spirit and positivity, always humming music. When the German friend left again, a Frenchman came with his girlfriend and a male friend, and there were five of us at the school with two local teachers and an animal caretaker, and Valentine's Day was coming, and the German girl and I had feelings for each other. One night by the fire, the French girl proposed that we massage one another, and the two couples paired off, the French lovers together, the German girl and I kissing, and I massaged her by the firelight, healing and romantic, and kissed her head and hugged her from behind, and she leaned into my chest and I kissed her neck and she my cheek, and we became lovers there, the French lovers whispering, "How cute." From that day we slept together in my room, not having sex for a week or more, only foreplay until she was ready; she had never had a boyfriend, a virgin, very gentle, and she loved it with me, and we went wild, and I realized how much I still had to explore, and how much I had lacked; I had not felt with the Chinese or French or American girls what I felt with her, and we had the best sex of my life, until we had to stop from exhaustion. She came for three months and decided to stay nine, which meant getting her a student visa, from a Kathmandu music school, and we even built a separate mud house near the goat shed to live in. Later the French lovers left, and two more Germans, an introvert artist and a man; around then I brought our adopted sister from my mother's place to study at the school, and life went

on. I fought crazily with my German lover sometimes, and made her cry, and she hurt me too; new to relationships, she missed some simple feelings of a man, and would make me jealous on purpose, once even going to sleep in a volunteer house where a lone German man stayed, just to provoke me, or sitting beside another man at gatherings, or mocking me before others, and I, as a man, did not like it, and we quarreled, though I should have made her understand gently and could not; still we got along, compromising and moving on. The Imperial College volunteers came again, thirteen of them, this time one boy and all girls, and I was overwhelmed, and they were wild, but heavy rains and landslides meant we could do little with the children. We ate a snake here again, a big one, my brother and adopted sister and German lover and a German guy and I, and I tried a different recipe, boiling it into a soup, and no one liked it. And here, at last, I learned to swim; it took many people, mostly Germans, my lover and my German friend teaching me some, until a German man gave me the final training, and I could float and dive and swim at ease, and I was so proud. Before my German lover left for Germany we took a long bike ride, Damak to Janakpur to Manthali to Kathmandu to Pokhara to Damauli and the central school and back to Kathmandu, and at the airport I felt it again, that I would not see her again, the end, and I shed some tears, my way of saying goodbye.

CHAPTER FORTY

The Living Gold

The end at the school came through that German friend, whose parents came to see the place; they had been helping greatly with sponsorship and donations from Germany, and wanted to see what they had supported. They explored and asked deeper questions and found the bitter truth of the place and its founders, the politics and the dark sides, and the father was furious to learn the central school in Damauli charged parents fees, though our branch did not. I had come believing it a free, ethical, volunteer school, and over time, with my access behind the curtain, I had seen the founder's plans to close our branch and focus on the central one, and his dislike of our giving free books and uniforms and excursions; I had been slowly blinded, and these parents reopened my eyes and my purpose, and we all cried many times together. They decided to stop supporting and to meet the founder, and my German friend decided to quit, and so did I. I had joined not for money, and worked as a volunteer there some three years; I only wanted to run the school in the most ethical way for the children and the community, but the founders had other things in mind, and in the last months he began to say he would pay me only to do what he approved, and I did not like that way, so I quit. I do not paint the founders as villains; they had built something real, and carried their own burdens and

their own vision, which simply was not mine. We wanted different things for the children, and when that became clear, the honest thing was to part, and I left with gratitude rather than bitterness. It was the most beautiful place I had lived, and it gave me a whole new world: the value of the next generation, how innocent children are and how the failing system slowly consumes them, the cultures and stories and languages and love of people from everywhere, an understanding of nature, and enough of every element to polish and plan my project.

After the school I went again to Vipassana, as a server, in Lumbini, to organize my life and my plans, and had a good, peaceful time, though there were more monkeys here to distract us, and some disturbing people who fed and teased them for a laugh; it was a relaxing rather than an intense time. Then I decided to work with my mother, who had moved to Manthali long before, after the earthquake, on a tender, and now had a big lumber and sawmill and furniture business doing well, a place I had visited before, alone and with my American and German lovers and other volunteers. They asked me to help, and bought me a new bike, and I began learning the trade from the inside out, starting with hunting for trees in villages and private and community forests.

My site was in Khotang, and I rode hundreds of kilometres a day, and I loved it, on a new bike that would do over a hundred. One day a dispute arose, for in this trade power and influence and money play a crucial game, not for ordinary wood but for the “living gold,” the special trees, where it turns political and dangerous, and I sat in on meetings with a forest officer, businessmen, and politicians, and watched these men

transfer police and officials at will, and understood that here it is power and money, not government, that truly speak, exactly as the conspiracies had said, the politicians only puppets. In that room no one cared about nature, wildlife, water, or the future; they wanted only money and power, to possess and consume and move on, to provide for their own family and kill the rest, and anyone who spoke of nature or healing would be crushed with rejection and laughter. It was the most evil, unethical, cruel demonstration of power I have ever seen, and the more disgusting thing was how, stepping out of that room, these same men became the most caring, loving actors of society. I kept reminding myself never to become such a man. I say this not out of hatred for those men, who are themselves caught in a game that rewards nothing but power, and rewards it richly, but as a warning I kept whispering to myself, that a person becomes what his room asks him to become, and that the only true rebellion is to build a different room.

In between I kept seeking. Hearing of Sadhguru and his “Inner Engineering,” I went alone to Lucknow, the nearest offering, expecting a place to stay and finding none, my little cash not enough in an expensive city, scammed by a tuk-tuk driver, until my brother’s Swedish girlfriend found me a hostel online where I stayed a week for the course. It was interesting but nothing new; I had learned it all already, a hyped and costly mixture of yoga and Vipassana, and I found it foolish and expensive for nothing when free and better versions existed. I came back to work with my mother. Then the American girl returned, as a Peace Corps teacher, and visited me in Damak, and when she learned I had a German lover she cried while

we shared our journeys, and asked why I had taken other lovers, and I said I was not hers, that our chapter had ended and I took it that we had ended for now, that I wanted to live free; she had had her own affairs, which I did not mind, and I was touched and confused by her tears, for she had perhaps come to feel for me as I had felt for my German lover. Slowly we began to date again, and my German lover cried, and it was all confusing, this complex thing of human connection and love; we agreed to live free and never possess or envy one another, and yet cried and wanted boundaries all the same, agreeing to keep exploring our own ways and yet coming back, until at one point I had a Chinese, a German, and an American love all sharing the same stories, and somehow we managed, for I had feelings and love for everyone. Later I went to the American girl's village where she taught, and we trekked with my brother and a student, and we even planned to have a child without marrying, until COVID sent an emergency evacuation and took her home, and the dream washed away, and we did not meet again.

My German lover and my mother both began urging me to Germany, for it is a thing in Nepal, to go abroad and make a life, but I did not want it; I had long decided to build my life in Nepal, and to go abroad only to travel, never to work, and I had made that clear to everyone, so they said to at least visit. I applied for the visa, and again that German friend and her parents helped, arranging the sponsorship and documents and insurance from Germany, and I planned to visit the school's volunteers, find places to volunteer, stay three months and come back. I passed the interview and was approved, ready to

go, and before leaving, some friends and I set out for a base camp, and as we left, the news of COVID grew louder, borders and countries shutting down, death news everywhere, and after some days my flight was cancelled, and I stopped dreaming of Germany.

CHAPTER FORTY-ONE

How Hunate Was Born

While the world closed, we did not. I was in Damak, and our family had a farm far from the city and the community, and my friends and I began spending our days there, playing football, sitting by the fire, drinking, sometimes sleeping under the open sky. We were far from everyone, with nothing else to do, all our plans cancelled, and so, on that ground, we decided to build our first hut and begin The Joon Project. And the work began.

By 2019 I had felt it clearly: I could not travel forever, I had no money, and I was tired. I had to build a place instead, an international hub where travellers came, so that I could keep travelling through their eyes and their stories and the cultures they carried. And I felt I had finally learned enough to build the place I had always wanted. That is how The Joon Project came, and we began working with artists, local people, scouts,

children, farmers, small businesses, musicians, orphanages, and international volunteers, doing many things without depending on money or politics or religion.

This journey took me through heaven and hell, and stretched me inside out, and polished me in many ways, and I value every moment of it, good and bad. Though I never had a proper family or a single teacher, life itself was always with me, and I kept learning. I trained and got certified as a yoga teacher and an international permaculture designer; I studied Ayurveda and the art of eating on my own, and astrology and vastu, and the basics of computing and graphic and web design; I can do some plumbing, electrical work, construction, carpentry; I write a great deal; I am a free thinker, an innovator, an improviser, an opportunist; I can judge a thing ethically; I am spiritual and not spiritual at once. I care about work and about the generations to come. I am angry at the world and happy in it. I am healthy, good at swimming and football and quick to learn any sport, and I do MMA for my health. I can play music and sing. I can love a woman. I can be a teacher and a student in the same breath, a leader and a follower when each is right, evil and good as needed. I am a visionary and a dreamer who has stayed true to his understanding and his heart and his purpose.

So, honestly, I do not know when Hunate was born. I think it was already inside me from a small age, from the time I first began to feel detached from society and the world. Phase One, this personal journey of self-discovery, began I do not know when; the curiosity was always there. Around 2013 I began to speak actively, and angrily, about the failing social system, its

problems and lies and conspiracies, among friends in Kathmandu and Damak, radical and wild about it, and out of all that debate and judgment the questions came back at me, from my friends and from myself: What is next? Where is the solution? What are you going to do about it? Do you have a way out? And then, slowly, I began to think of the solutions. And I began to live them too.

PART SEVEN

The Joon Project

*A hut built by hand in a locked-down world,
Friday fires and free music, an orphanage
turned into a home, a festival without money,
and the slow becoming of the thing that
would be called Hunate.*

CHAPTER FORTY-TWO

Start With What You Have

The seed had been sown years before. Back in 2015, returned from India where I had gone to learn yoga and meditation and Ayurveda, and volunteering at Maya Universe, I came to Kathmandu to present an idea to my friends. We were a diverse bunch, young and a little crazy, geologists and social engineers and computer whizzes, and I could see us building a community together, because we already had everything we needed among us. My brother, a geology student, would find the right land, rich in water and materials and sun. A civil engineer and architect would design the houses; a farmer would teach us abundance; mechanical and computer engineers would make the place run on renewable energy; social engineers would connect us to the world and start a community school; a cinematographer would film our story, and media people would carry it out to the world. We did not have to be perfect or world-class; we had only to be young amateur founders and visionaries, and push ourselves into working as a team. I was more radical then, wanting if possible to erase the use of money altogether, to stop consuming factory goods and what the Western media fed us, to create

our own music, houses, business modules, community structure, and education. I knew that once we all finished college everyone would scatter into family and career and the potential would be wasted, and I wanted us to start together while we could. So around 2015 and 2016 I presented The Joon Project officially to my larger circle, and then I went on travelling.

And in 2019, finally, we began to build. This phase was an experiment, to make an international hub where like-minded people could gather and share ideas, skills, stories, and cultures, and search together for alternative ways to live in harmony among humanity, nature, and technology. When COVID froze the world, my friends and I, home again with nothing to do, gathered at my family's farm far from the town. We were free, so we travelled first, about ten of us on five bikes, since everyone had come home for the pandemic, riding to Rabi for a night and up to see the sunrise from Ilam, though at one village they nearly refused us entry, still afraid of the virus; it was a cheap, wonderful ride on new roads. And then, back at the farm, we decided to build.

The place seemed like nowhere: land my family used only to plant rice once a year, with one old broken hut of straw and wood, a spring across a small creek, bamboo all around, no road and no electricity, reachable only on a ten- or fifteen-minute walk from where we left the bikes. It was calm and clean and quiet, and we would fish and hunt and lie in hammocks and barbecue and sing all day. We had almost nothing, just some tools donated from my mother's furniture shop and a big dream, but I learned that building a community means waking up and acting with what is already around you, rather

than waiting on an NGO, the government, or divine intervention. Our first task was a water pump, and the water came out red with iron, or perhaps we had not gone deep enough, and it took time and a filter before it ran clear; the cement base was so heavy it took four of us more than an hour to drag it fifteen minutes through the flooded, slippery monsoon paddy, soaked and covered in mud, dragging it inch by inch, exciting and tiring both. Then I designed a hut, and we carried the wood in piece by piece and built it slowly, over many seasons, I living there alone while friends came each day to help, everyone excited to have something to do while the world had stopped. We could not finish it in one go; I raised the frame and roof, then had to stop when the heavy rains came, and went off to earn a little more money, and came back the next year to build again. In time it held our kitchen and office and store, and at night ten or more of us slept scattered, under the open sky, on hammocks, in the old hut, on the rice hay. When we finally opened it to international volunteers, who paid fifteen dollars a day, it grew easier.

COVID itself taught me something. We were far from the city and, honestly, careless; we kept playing in the mud, and none of us fell seriously ill, while the city, in all its hygiene and comfort, suffered first. I came to believe that our bodies need a certain exposure to the dirt and bacteria of nature to build their resilience, and that the modern habit of sanitizing everything is a misleading kind of health. I heard of countries blaming one another, of vaccines sold to poor nations, of fear despite all their wealth, though truly I only heard it and to this day do not know what to believe, for no one around me died.

And none of the modern medicine or science or city structure helped; it was the villages and distant homes, closer to nature, that endured. It confirmed what we had felt all along: that no human is greater than nature, that we are a part of it and not above it, and that we must build every system, our medicine and education and economy and borders and technology, on nature's law.

CHAPTER FORTY-THREE

Friday Music

We started something new, a free live music session every Friday, to connect with the young people of Damak. We had no fancy equipment or world-class musicians, only talented people from our own community, and that was more than enough. We gathered local artists in our old broken animal-shed hut, decorated it with natural things, and filmed, and it was raw and real and full of passion. It grew quickly, because Damak is a small, warm place where news travels fast, and it is my home town, my generation scattered through it in just the right places. When word spread of the project and of international people coming, people grew excited and asked how to join, and among them was a musician with a wide reach across the district, and he carried the idea and brought

the musicians and instruments while I brought the place and the guidance and the way to make it happen without money. Session after session, more players and locals and friends from afar joined, and the vibe kept growing; we were sharing not just songs but stories and dreams. We filmed the second session inside Hamro Bal Ashram, the orphanage, which was a wholly new thing for the children, who were happy and shocked; one song was about drugs, and the artist felt bad to sing it there, an awkward moment we got past, and we invited him back for another event. In the same spirit we helped our friends: cleaning and organizing one friend's new restaurant in exchange for food, building a table for another, trading work for work, and it worked well.

Around this time one of our members introduced a girl to me, who came to visit and then left. In time she said she liked to read and borrowed a book from me, and I made sure she returned it, and when I came back from Manthali we met to return it and went straight on a date, walking for hours around Damak, and she was nice, and I invited her to stay at my house. She agreed; she smoked and used a little, and that night we were together and had crazy sex, and she loved it, amazed at my stamina, and I was proud, for I was living healthy then. We dated a while, until once she borrowed six books from me at once and never returned them; she and her family had changed houses, her phone was dead, even her friends did not know where she had gone. She was an introvert who believed deeply in dark magic and ghosts, and perhaps she left Damak, and that is how it ended.

Once, with my brother's friend, I went to visit the eastern hill village and school where we had both once been principal. It was the rainy season, and at one point we had to carry our bike across a river with the villagers' help, but it was a worthy trip; we met everyone again, family after all, the same respect and love, and we brought gifts, and it was fun.

CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

The Roads and the Girl

In February 2021 my friend, the one helping organize the music sessions, bought a new bike, and we set off on a long ride, from Damak to Dharan to Hile to Dhankuta. On the slippery red-mud road at Pakhribas we had our first fall; I was alone on my bike when it simply slid out, and it was so funny that my friend, instead of helping, started filming me, and the villagers, seeing him laugh, laughed too and stopped coming to help. We rode on to my mother's birthplace, spent some days, then took gravel roads toward Taplejung, past lakes and Basantapur, riding on snow and rough terrain, not knowing where the roads would lead, hearing of bears and tigers killing goats, eating local food, crossing lands of yaks and sheep and horses and landscapes like Switzerland. At last we reached Pathivara, one of the most worshipped places in eastern Nepal,

and my friend fell sick with fever there, so we rested and climbed the next morning; he walked slowly, so I went ahead into the cold and snow and fog, and when he was still climbing I went back down and up again with him, and then we drove home to Damak, and I rode the whole way, and it was amazing.

In March 2021 I began posting our platform on volunteering sites, and volunteers started to come. Around then my youngest uncle on my mother's side invited my brother and me to start a project on his land in Bhojpur, so we went, carrying construction and farming tools in our backpacks, walking two or three hours to a beautiful, isolated place, no road or electricity, the nearest house an hour away, where small villages had emptied as everyone left for the city. We helped renovate the old houses, a place I had visited as a small child, now ruined and being restored by my uncle to farm and live in; grandparents were already farming there, raising chickens and goats and cows, with other helpers chopping trees and building, and I cooked and watered plants and grazed animals and built and slept in nature on a hammock, with barely a mobile signal, among fruit trees and peacocks and wildlife. We thought to make it a project hub too, but a young French boy who came to volunteer could not walk the hilly paths or digest the food and soon fell sick and left, and a kind Indian couple came and helped a great deal and are still in touch, and in the end I decided to bring the project back to Damak, where it was hard to transport goods or find a community to work with, too isolated for anyone to reach; Damak was better placed, with community and children and roads. When the monsoon came we planted rice with family and friends and local helpers, and

there is something special about getting your hands in the soil to plant the food you will eat; in Nepal rice is more than food, it is flour and noodles and beaten rice and puffed rice, and it sustains us all year.

Stressed, or I do not know why, I started hunting for lovers, talking to four girls at once: one from Sikkim, a naughty one; a Nepali girl studying to be a pilot in South Africa; a teacher from a nearby town; and one from my own home town, a former Miss Damak, and I liked the idea of a girl from Damak itself. I found her on Facebook, beautiful, a former Miss Damak and Miss Bishwakarma of the eastern region, and began with a little flirting. Then one day, riding home from a friend's hotel, not happy, I passed a girl at a junction on the back of another bike, she going south and I going west, both masked and helmeted, and still we knew each other, and smiled, and waved; I wrote to her the moment I reached home, and that was our first meeting. Over a coffee and a hot chocolate I found her sweet and soft-spoken and innocent, almost too good for me, and I thought I should step back rather than hurt her, and I found too that she was the sister of the very friend who helped me with the music sessions and had introduced me to the book-borrowing girl, which left me confused. I went back to Manthali to my mother, and there I fell terribly sick, my whole body and bones aching, one of the worst sicknesses I have had, maybe COVID, though I took no medicine and healed over a week and more, bathing and walking barefoot in nature with my many dogs, eating fresh, taking herbs, staying positive. All the while I kept talking to the Miss Damak girl on the phone. Back in Damak, a childhood friend got married a

second time, a blast of a party where I met many school friends and felt they still saw me as they had, charismatic, with respect and authority, and I liked feeling that old position, and we drank and danced and celebrated like crazy.

CHAPTER FORTY-FIVE

The Orphanage

After grounding ourselves, we opened the platform to the world, inviting travellers and like-minded souls to share their cultures and languages and skills and food, and it was an incredible exchange, seeing the world through their eyes. And we joined hands with a local orphanage. We had not been looking for one, but we learned of it nearby, some of its board members seniors from my old school, and having worked with children before, I went to visit, and the idea came, for our hut and farm were settled and there was not much else to do. We stepped in to help transform it, not just a shelter for orphans but a true home, as organizers and mentors and friends and family, designing routines and food plans and study sessions, running workshops, and above all offering love. It breaks my heart that orphanages exist at all; it is a reflection of a broken system. But rather than only criticize, we chose to act, and to work toward a society that would not need them.

The children were living on donations, given clothes and gifts and food they did not value, using things once and throwing them away, wasting what came for free. So we gave them responsibility. We divided the older ones into groups, each keeping the records of one thing: finance and donations, stationery, the kitchen and food stock, clothes, entertainment and sport, the timetable and hygiene. And every Friday they held a meeting where the children were in charge and all of us, the staff and founders and board, had to sit in silence and listen. They had to act like adults, to plan for themselves, to watch over everything and analyse it and find their own problems and solutions, even to watch for corruption done in their name, and they loved it; they felt they belonged, felt authority and freedom and ownership, and understood how the different parts of a life connect. It became our whole way of working: before any task or event we would sit in a circle and plan together, list everything needed, the skills and tools and time, and then let each person choose freely what to do and who to work with, all of us toward one shared goal and one celebration. On Friday nights we gathered under the stars around a fire, cooked on wood, ate dal-bhat and told stories, the children as fire-builders and vegetable-washers and rice-watchers, no captains, no hierarchy, only equal responsibility for shared joy. That is the society we dream of, built not on caste or class or command but on contribution and cooperation.

We gave them more than records. We taught them yoga and meditation, not to discipline them but to give them tools to find calm within chaos, to feel that they were enough and safe inside themselves. We gave them art, telling them to close

their eyes and breathe and visit a memory and then draw, not to impress or compete but simply to express; their imagination mattered, their emotions mattered. We taught them classical music too, on a few harmoniums donated by the community, until the whole room, even the caretakers, was singing together; music made us all equal, and we did it for the soul and not for the stage. We took them beyond the classroom to wood workshops and pottery studios, because education is not four walls but a whole community, a whole city of real work and real people. And on their days off we took them to the river to run and scream and get wet and be wild, and I would stand by and say, I am here, do what your heart wants; that is how children grow, not through rules and fear but by being trusted to explore. It breaks my heart that many children never feel this, pressed to become money-making machines from a young age, childhood locked behind textbooks and timetables. I do not believe you can measure a child in a lab in a few weeks; it takes twenty-five years to raise one, and I lived the kind of life these children live, and came out fine, and we never know who will become what, or what a child will choose to keep in memory. All I knew was to keep opening them to the world, its cultures and stories and myths and music and skills and love, to show them the real world and how to use money, how to run the home themselves and keep the records and lead the small ones and follow the older. The difficult ones I kept beside me, showing them how I think and work and act in different situations, guiding them to handle their emotions and to express and accept themselves as they are. Every moment was rewarding; the children learned new

things, we brought new ideas to the community, and I learned the psychology of orphaned children and how society sees and treats them.

CHAPTER FORTY-SIX

The World Comes to the Farm

Once we posted the platform, the world began to arrive, and we built to hold it, temporary shelters of bamboo and huge plastic tarps, an old hut, personal tents, hammocks. This is what I always tell the youth: stop complaining about not having enough, start where you are with what you have, for your community already holds what you need. Foreigners came to live on a farm in tents, using open toilets, bathing in the river, and the villagers thought us crazy, until slowly they saw us for what we were and accepted us, excited to watch us build what we needed with our own hands.

Three wild, athletic boys from France came at once, from the same circle, into adventure sports, who got many tattoos in Damak and drew the town's interest, and for them we built a shelter. We built an organic spiral toilet with no door, where you had to use a little telepathy to know if it was occupied and carry your own water from afar, which gave both exercise and

peace; some visitors, the girls especially, did not love it, and we embraced it anyway. When mud and leakage troubled our water pump, we rebuilt it with cement and stone, and once we got into the rhythm of creating, one project led to another as if nature itself were guiding us. One night a wild storm blew our tents apart around one in the morning, and we ran about in the dark with our headlamps, shouting and laughing in the strong, clean wind, gathering our clothes; more than a disaster it felt like entertainment, and the next day we rebuilt stronger, having learned the weakness, and it never blew down again.

The kind Indian couple who had first come to our Bhojpur land returned, this time with cameras, and stayed on and off, family to us, the boy a shy philosophy type and an actor, the girl a cinematographer, who could not pay the fee but helped with everything, cooking and farming and building and filming, easy-going and wonderful. An Englishman came with his own tent, an easy, understanding man who identified as gay and helped us greatly even after leaving, now in Australia. An American came who had been teaching for years in China and was on his way home, a gentle, chill man with whom I had many conversations about life and the world; he taught the orphanage children though he needed a break from them, waiting for his Chinese girlfriend, and he helped at the art fair and sold some postcards, and loved Nepali beer, which he drank in secret, pretending not to be drunk, which was cute; so gentle that he painted the rooms before his girlfriend visited, and loved photographing the fields, and loved taking the children to the farm to learn in nature. His girlfriend, a teacher in China too, soon came, a nice girl who helped with the chil-

dren and cooked Chinese food, and then the two left to tour the world together. A sweet, kind girl came from Colombia and Argentina, teaching the children yoga and art in the mornings; a young Frenchman, very quiet and very funny, who loved building at the farm with our parents; a gentle, spiritual IT man from Gujarat, India, one of the best cooks we ever had; and a gentle man from Chile, slow and relaxed, who had an underwear brand back home, loved photographing men, gave good massages that eased my labouring days, ate Nepali noodles every day, and got a phoenix tattoo with our friend. Every one of them carried a story and a lesson.

CHAPTER FORTY-SEVEN

A Festival Without Money

A boy from the Scouts visited the farm, loved what we were doing, and proposed a special Scout night camp for children, and I said, let's do it. The Damak Scouts took the lead, and we spent days planning, gathering wood, prepping food, building spaces, setting up games, and then came the night of laughter and songs and stories and shared meals under the stars. It was more than a camp; it was a reminder that community is not a place but people who show up for each other.

We decided to build a big volunteer house to hold at least ten volunteers, and bought wood for sixty thousand rupees and carried it to the project. While I was away in Ilam for a few days and my brother was leaving too, he put all the wood into the river to season it and make it stronger, though I warned him it was unnecessary, as it was already hardwood. And when I came back from Ilam, our plan and our wood and our dream were gone; a crazy rain and storm had come, and the river had taken everything, the wood, the crops, all of it. It was very painful, and I was frustrated and angry, and I blamed my brother, though what good was it now; he was innocent, only trying to help. Our plan had to stop until we had money again, and we went on living in tents. It was a reminder never to leave one thing unfinished to start another; finish the work you have begun.

That Ilam trip had been for Dashain, four of us, the Scout boy, a volunteer, and another friend, up into the hills to the Scout boy's village, where his mother lived alone on a beautiful land from which you could see the plains; the people welcomed us like family, and, thinking of land for the project, even offered us houses and a school, and we camped on a hill-top by a fire with a three-hundred-and-sixty-degree view of Indian and Nepali cities like a panorama, and it felt like a dream, though for now we stayed rooted where we were.

Then we held our annual Joon Camp Festival, and we did it entirely without money. We sold no tickets, took no permission, called no mayor or politician, asked no sponsor, and still everything happened. We convinced the businesses of Damak to share the tools and skills and hands they had; we rented in-

struments, gathered volunteers, and built eight stalls ourselves, a live music stage, a live painting space, a free health checkup, a wood-craft workshop, an adventure-gear stall, a book stall, and a free hand-poke bamboo tattoo stall, with three fire places for the night and tents to sleep in, and we gathered and shared our own food. Many took the free tattoo, most of them the moon, the Joon, and I got my first hand-poke tattoos too, a moon on my left hand and a sun on my right. Villagers came, confused at first and then delighted, and the orphan children came, and strangers became friends; it was the message we wanted to send, that it is possible without money if we truly want it. I even invited the Miss Damak girl, though we were barely talking any more and had almost given up the idea of being together, and she came with two of her sisters, who all got moon tattoos, and they had a good time.

After the festival, the Miss Damak girl, the Scout boy and his lover and I travelled to a school deep in Bhojpur and Khotang that I had long wanted to see, a kind of date through which I hoped to understand her; I had to go to her house and ask her parents' permission, which they granted. We bused to Bhojpur and stayed a night at my maternal home, and I played the local guide through the bazaar and the temples of my birth district, then went to Tamke, and one day, walking with confidence toward the school, I led us four hours the wrong way until a traveller set us right. When we reached it, a volunteer who had applied to the Joon Project happened to be there and became our host, and the founder was a bold, disciplined, healthy old man, and the school was exactly what I dream of building: children doing their mathematics in the field as they

planted seeds and drew lines and predicted harvests, others keeping the animals, filming the day's news for the dining hall, working with machines and tractors, sewing, building classrooms, studying in the library, cooking in the kitchen, all of them awake before sunrise for exercise and cleaning, their skills classes changing every year. We returned to Damak full and fulfilled, and I had learned much, about that school and about the girl I was coming to love.

CHAPTER FORTY-EIGHT

The Girl from Damak

Toward the end of 2021 the tattoo brothers, the founder of the Purva art fair who had inked my moon and his brother who had done my sun, wanted to travel wild and free the way I do, and since the Scout boy was moving to India with his father, we set off together, east toward Nagaland by way of the father's village, packing our camera and tattoo machine and ukulele and hats. We looked like a caravan, tattooed and heavy-backpacked, the centre of attention everywhere, inspected extra at the borders, our phones and photos checked to prove we were Nepali. From New Jalpaiguri we took a train to Guwahati, and there the adventure began: another man who had done my moon tattoo and I were smoking at the station

when an undercover cop demanded a fine, twenty-four hundred rupees for the two of us, or two hundred each to be let go, and I refused, saying I do not corrupt people, and he took us to the station twenty metres away before I could act, and I felt stupid, our train about to leave, and in the end I whispered that we would give the two hundred, and he laughed, “Just now you said you don’t do corruption,” funny and insulting at once, and I paid and we left. We told the others only that we had a crazy time, letting them guess. On the train, as it grew dark, a squad of armed police stopped at our compartment, looked us over head to toe, and asked for tickets, and ours were only waitlisted, which I had not known, and they called me to follow, and I brought along the clever friend who had done my sun tattoo. They took us to an empty compartment and told us the train was theirs until some station, that it was night and no one would know what they did, threatening us for twelve hundred each; so I played dumb, acting as if I knew no Hindi, speaking only English and Nepali, while my friend pretended to half-translate, and back and forth it went, me showing the ticket, them saying money, until they grew so frustrated they said they would throw us all off at the next station, and I only smiled and said, all right, all right, and their officer told a constable to take us and put us off, and halfway there the constable simply left us, and we went back to our seats, and the ticket collector soon confirmed our tickets without any fine, and we breathed in relief, and I teased my terrified friends, asking how they liked the adventure.

Before dawn, as we neared our station, everyone asleep, I checked the map and, seeing us close as the train slowed, woke everyone to hurry and packed in a rush, and when it started moving again we all ran to the door and I told them to jump into the dark without looking, and one by one we jumped, the small friend who had done my sun tattoo crushed and rolled down the track by his heavy bag, and the train left, and we stood in silence realizing it was not a station at all; my miscalculation again, six kilometres out, and they were angry and laughing at once as we walked, joking about the jump, like a bunch of idiots at daybreak. We reached the real station and took a bus to Shillong, our ukulele always out, singing on train and station and roadside, people loving it, and before Shillong a big COVID-vaccine check. We arrived on Christmas Eve, everything booked, and after hours of walking with heavy backpacks and no place to stay, we slept in our sleeping bags at the bus stop in the cold. The next day a taxi took us toward Meghalaya, the driver bringing us to his home where our tattoo boys inked him too and he fed us tea and biscuits, and we reached green water and colourful boats near the Bangladesh border, hiking where people warned us not to go, sleeping in a local hut for a small fee, swimming without paying, wild and singing, welcomed and liked, before returning to Nepal with stories to last a long time.

In January 2022 the Miss Damak girl and I began dating and falling in love, and we both decided to leave Damak for Kathmandu, she to find work and I to help my mother a while, and I went to Manthali, where I built an art easel as a gift for the tattoo friends, and visited her when I could while she lived

with a friend and joined a mobile-wallet company. That March the tattoo friends asked me to help organize the second Purva art fair, which had suffered political pressure and registrations and complaints, and I restructured it the Joon way: cutting the registrations and the invitations to politicians and famous names, giving equal space to every artist big and small, making everyone pay to attend, even the organizers, because every art is built with passion and every emotion matters, and it was a blast, with no complaints, every artist valued. Then a three-star hotel invited us to supply some two thousand abstract paintings, and I came from Manthali for the meeting, but they wanted cheap work at a thousand rupees a piece, when we sold a single painting for ten thousand to a lakh, and, insulted, we dropped it. We travelled together too, once to my mother's timber worksite in Lamjung, to a mad-honey hunting village and a tunnel that ran toward China. When her hostel phone was stolen and she moved to a room in Kathmandu, I helped her settle, and we kept meeting, and when she applied for the USA we went by train to Kolkata for her interview, my first time there, staying with a couch-surfing host who lent us his scooter, and when her visa was rejected she wept and threw away the rings her astrologer had given her, and I calmed her and rode her around the city, and we came home resolved to build our own life and work in Nepal. In September 2022 we came back to Damak to restart the Joon Project, and I went to her house to ask permission to take her as my project partner and to have her stay at the project, and she and her parents agreed. She promised to help me with this work all her life.

CHAPTER FORTY-NINE

The Joon Way

We kept moving closer to the community. First we had to shift into a concrete house, not where we wanted to be but where we had to be, for the farm was too far for people to find and we had to close the platform every monsoon to plant and harvest the rice; a contact house let people and international volunteers find us and let us work all year, and gather the local children to teach our ways. We shifted to a second contact house nearer the farm, for which I went to Manthali to build the furniture, six beds and a dining table, and brought it back to assemble, pouring love into every corner until it was a home and a bridge between dreams and people. And then to a third, closer still to the orphanage and the farm and the road, a whole house for cheap rent with land for gardening, the best place, where we grew a great deal and could host more travellers and children and volunteers and ideas.

To sustain ourselves we started a pickle business with my partner's mother's recipes, radish and chilli and mixed and bamboo-shoot, and added peanut butter and organic honey and multigrain satv; we sold it all and kept making more. And teaching became our real currency. We hosted a permaculture workshop, inviting friends and families and local children and curious minds, sharing seeds and plants and a vision of sustainable living, for farming is not just a job but an art and a

community and a healing, and the children learned soil and cycles and connection, seed care and natural compost and design. With the donated art-fair money I started a “School of Life,” taking the children to workshops around the town on holidays; I went to local businesses and asked them to host our children once a week, and everyone was glad to cooperate, and so we built an education circle across the town, learning from real, practical, working teachers, permaculture and gardening, wood and music, yoga and meditation, art and poetry and speech, organization and record-keeping and finance, nature exploration and sport. We were trying to make an alternative education system where the whole town was the school, and every person who ran a business or a workshop was a real-life teacher, opening a small town to the world as a hub for anyone who wanted new ideas and new ways to live, connecting children and orphans and parents and villagers and artists and youths and businesses and travellers and farmers. Imagine what that could do to a human. We even organized a sustainable-business-module workshop with a French boy and an Indian boy, to share ethical business ways among friends, though it did not go as planned, and was an experience.

Along the way I lost my faith in a certain kind of charity. A women’s social club came to the orphanage for a free eye-checkup, warm and well-meaning, and yet I have seen too much behind the scenes to believe fully in that kind of service. I have read that most donated things never reach the people they are meant for, finished on the way by the airplanes and hotels of a professional charity class; it is often a way to cut taxes, a cheating. In our culture we say, give without expecting

anything in return, and that is what service means to me, something in the soul and the DNA, not in a policy that promises a tax deduction. I lived among such organizations in Kathmandu and watched funds arrive from around the world so that a few students could be sent on a week-long village trip to impose city and Western ways they did not understand, following orders for grades or a post or a story to tell, while no one could say where the money went or how it helped. I have met people who spent an hour at an orphanage only to fill a quota to run for office in their own organization, and people who opened orphanages to build political influence, and places that took donor money for the children's food and clothes while charging the parents for the same. Where the UN is, there is more of what it fights; where the WHO is, more disease; people fight global warming while flying airplanes and living in luxury. The game is built on bad morality. There are good people and good projects too, everywhere, and the workers are only human and need to live; it is the system that seems off, and we must simply find what is good and hold to it.

Not every day was big. Some were a bike ride to Chapeti with fifteen or twenty of us, or a hike to a waterfall with volunteers and my partner's sisters. We had one mountain bicycle for twenty thousand rupees, and when it was stolen I was so sad it felt like my legs had broken. We celebrated Christmas and the New Year with the VC brothers, friends from town who had seen me working with the children and wanted to help, and I invited them to celebrate with us, cooking and singing and dancing around the firelight, not as a religion but as a

family. We introduced classical music sessions and study time with the children, sitting with them over their homework not as teachers but as friends and brothers and sisters, and revived a patch of donated plants that had been forgotten, dividing the roles and bringing the green space back to life, because when you give something you must give your time too. And when the American-from-China volunteer helped at the third Purva art fair in February 2023, we went a little off: many renowned old artists came from all over Nepal and from India, and the founder gave them respectful attention on the stage, and the local artists felt shadowed and complained, and I too had my doubts, aware of the difference from the second year, though the money was meant to fund the children's workshops; there I met a hospitality college that asked me to design their cafe, a five-lakh deal we began well, until they paid so late, and I value punctuality so much, that with mutual understanding we stopped halfway, and I gave all the promised furniture for what they had paid, leaving only the finishing, and took the leftover machines and iron rods and roof tins for the Joon Project. With our parents' investment we built a big living space at the farm, and my father and mother and my father's sister came to live there, and from the college project's leftovers we built an open extension at the front of the contact house, which became our library and a place to teach the children and park the bikes and drink our morning tea.

CHAPTER FIFTY

Joon Becomes Hunate

At some point the orphanage we worked with was merged with another under government order and moved to a bigger place across the city, with political currents running behind it, too far for us to visit daily to continue our work. The new orphanage asked us to carry on, but it was far, and we did not like waiting on political approval to do anything, for I liked to work independently, as we wished. So instead we began inviting local families and teaching the village children for free, and the parents came and registered their children gladly, and we ran our workshops as we had for the orphans, and the villagers loved it.

Then the halt came. My brother left the country to travel and to meet his Swedish wife after years apart, and one of our project's co-founders, my partner, lost her father to a hit-and-run on the highway, carried to hospital by strangers. Saving him became our only priority. I could not give much money, but through our connections we raised enough by crowdfunding, and in that moment we understood that though we had earned no money in all these years, we had earned people, supporters spread quietly around the whole world, friend telling friend, aunt telling uncle, the music circle and the volunteers all giving, and we had not even known it, and we were deeply grateful. It has been about two years now, and we are

still treating him, here and there, in Nepal and India, and in that time we stopped the project and halted everything. She had promised to help me with this project all her life; so I made a vow to help her as long as her father needed her, and from that day I have stayed with her, helping her and her father.

I have had moments when I wanted to reopen it, and I did not. Instead I have kept working day and night in another way, reflecting, re-evaluating, redocumenting, redesigning the past for a better future. I take this time as the old saying goes, whatever happens, happens for a reason, and the reason is to be at peace, to plan well, to stay disciplined and humble and grateful. And in this quiet, The Joon Project has become Hunate.

I see the whole arc now. Phase One was my own life, a journey of self-discovery, full of curiosity and silence and pain and healing, of self-learning through self-questioning, of anger and wildness and complaint, the long effort to break through. Phase Two was The Joon Project; Joon means moon in Nepali, and it was a symbolic thing, an attempt to build a fresh community as if on the clean face of the moon, a new civilization where the broken systems of the earth did not apply, an experiment where I combined everything I had learned into an international hub and kept learning from the cultures of the world. And Phase Three is Hunate, coming back to the community. We are not running any more. We have healed, and accepted the earth and the problems we all created unknowingly,

and we want to help it heal and come back to the right track. We are one family. We forgive, and we move to do better, together, and we bring our findings to share with everyone.

Through all of it, we registered nowhere. We called no mayor and no politician, went to no NGO, and did it ourselves as ordinary citizens of a country and of the earth, and that is the spirit we want to keep. Many travellers and volunteers and guests passed through, for the party, to escape, to help, to guide us, to seek guidance, and every one carried a story and a lesson, because every human does; it is up to us to choose to remember and share and care and support each person's journey. We planned and failed to plan, we worked like machines and grew lazy and took breaks, and that is life, and we did it our way, controlling what we could and leaving the rest to nature. We worked locally, only as far as we could reach in a day; we never tried to change the whole world, only to create our own small, true circle within it.

This project is life itself, with no start and no end. It will keep changing and flowing and evolving as the human world does. We are still planning, still caring for a father's health, still reflecting and documenting, and when we are both truly ready, we will carry what we have found from all three phases to the wider community, to raise awareness of the failing social system, to help families and individuals and schools and businesses and orphanages reflect and redesign their lives, from birth onward, toward a natural, regenerative way of living. Until that day, in the quiet, in the shadows, Hunate keeps getting ready. And so do I.